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CONTRABAND HUMANISM

Ligature, Mētis, and the Theft of the General Equivalent in Lana and Lilly Wachowski's Bound *(1996)*



Corky *Violet*

PAYABLE TO THE BEARER, NOT TO THE HEIR

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A dissertation

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Abstract

Bound (1996), the first feature written and directed by Lana and Lilly Wachowski, has been received chiefly as a virtuosic genre exercise, as an artifact of mid-1990s "lesbian chic," or as the technical rehearsal for *The Matrix* (1999). This dissertation argues instead that the film is a philosophically systematic text whose narrative of theft encodes a coherent theory of the human, and of who has historically been permitted to possess it. Its central claim is that the object of *Bound*'s heist is not merely two million dollars of laundered Mafia capital but the humanist subject-position itself. Caesar, the launderer in whom the film condenses every figure that Jean-Joseph Goux identified as a "general equivalent" (money, father, phallus, sovereign, logos), is robbed and finally killed by two women whom the humanist tradition excluded from its patrimony: Corky, a working-class butch ex-convict whose intelligence is lodged in her hands, and Violet, a femme who has circulated as a token within a homosocial economy of exchange.

What the women expropriate, I contend, is the set of goods that canonical humanism reserved for a fraternal subject: friendship as the fusion of souls (Montaigne), emergence from tutelage (Kant), the right to make and keep promises (Nietzsche, Arendt), sovereignty over one's own consent (La Boétie), and freedom as the willing of another's freedom (Beauvoir). The film re-founds these goods upon what I term the *ligature*: a bond that binds without bondage, constituted through erotic knowledge (Lorde), cunning intelligence (*mētis*, after Detienne and Vernant), and the practical reason of the laboring hand. The resulting formation I name *contraband humanism*: a humanism that cannot be inherited through the patrilineal channels by which the Western tradition transmitted "the human," and which can therefore only

be smuggled across the boundaries (the *bandi*, or bans) through which that tradition constituted itself by exclusion.

The argument unfolds in eight chapters. Chapter One reads the Mafia "Family" as a kinship machine in the sense of Lévi-Strauss, Rubin, Pateman, and Irigaray, and the film's literalized money laundering as a staging of Marx's commodity fetish and of Nietzsche's economy of debt and cruelty. Chapter Two reconstructs the film's epistemology of the closet through Sedgwick, Castle, and Wittig, recovering an unremarked classical intertext in the Bona Dea scandal and the dictum that Caesar's wife must be above suspicion. Chapter Three theorizes the protagonists as agents of *mētis*, drawing on de Certeau, Ahmed, Heidegger and Derrida on the hand, Irigaray's mechanics of fluids, Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage, and Adorno and Horkheimer's bound Odysseus.

Chapter Four argues that *Bound* resolves the prisoner's dilemma that structures the noir lineage of James M. Cain by converting distrust into erotic knowledge, and reads the film against Arendt on promise and violence, Montaigne and La Boétie on friendship and tyranny, Derrida on the fraternal politics of friendship, and Jessica Benjamin on the bonds of love. Chapter Five situates the film's formal strategies (its acoustic regime, its infrastructural camera, its refusal of the noir death sentence) within feminist film theory and the history of lesbian representation. Chapter Six develops a disciplined trans hermeneutics grounded in Freudian *Nachträglichkeit*, tracing the film's figures through the Wachowskis' subsequent work. Chapter Seven tests the thesis against the feminist and humanist canons and against four substantial objections: the neoliberal capture of emancipation, the film's whiteness, the voyeuristic economy of "lesbian chic," and the ethics of tyrannicide.

Chapter Eight formalizes contraband humanism in twelve theses. A coda reads the film's final exchange, in which the "difference" between the lovers is answered by a shared unknowing, as the resolution of a chiasmus that structures the whole work: the sovereign's *ignorant knowledge* set against the lovers' *learned ignorance*.

Note on Nomenclature, Citation, and Method

Bound was released under a sibling credit that its makers have since retired; the 2024 Criterion restoration re-credits the film to "The Wachowskis" and to Lana and Lilly Wachowski. This study uses those names throughout and reproduces no earlier ones. Dialogue is quoted sparingly and only where exact wording bears analytic weight. Plot particulars follow the release version and are checked against the production record, including the 1997 commentary recorded by the directors, the principal cast, editor Zach Staenberg, and consultant Susie Bright.

Classical and early modern texts are cited by their standard divisions: Stephanus pages for Plato, book and chapter for Herodotus and Plutarch, paragraph numbers for Hegel's *Phenomenology*, essay and section for Nietzsche, book and chapter for Montaigne's *Essais*. Translations from French, German, Greek, and Latin are the author's unless a published translation is named in the Works Cited.

One distinction governs every claim about sources. *Documented influences* are those the filmmakers or their collaborators have named on the record: Billy Wilder and the noir tradition; Frank Miller's *Sin City* as a visual model for Bill Pope's cinematography; John Huston's *The Treasure of the Sierra Madre* (1948) as the template the directors gave Joe Pantoliano for Caesar's paranoia; and the sex-positive feminism of Susie Bright, which entered the production directly through her choreography of the sex scenes. *Cultural sources* are the vernacular repertoires the film visibly mobilizes (butch-femme iconography, the labrys tattooed on Corky's arm, a lesbian bar whose extras were Bright's

friends, in her words "real life San Francisco dykes") or plausibly invokes (the violet as a coded flower of Sapphic love). *Philosophical genealogies* are lineages of thought whose problems the film restages. No claim is made that the Wachowskis read any given philosopher. The question this dissertation pursues is not what the authors intended but what the work knows.

Introduction

The Wall, the Bond, and the Problem of Inheritance

The first image of *Bound* is a closet. After the title, the camera moves through a confined interior, Violet's closet, until it discovers Corky on the floor, beaten, bound, and gagged (by Caesar, the film will reveal), while a voice-over speaks of choice. A film about two women who rob the Mafia thus opens by literalizing the governing metaphor of twentieth-century sexual politics and then tying a body up inside it. The gesture announces a method the work sustains with unusual rigor: *Bound* takes the master figures of its culture at their word. The closet becomes a closet. The Family becomes a family, complete with a patriarch, an heir, and a disputed succession. Laundering becomes the washing, ironing, and line-drying of banknotes stained with an embezzler's blood. The thin partition between two apartments becomes the membrane through which every decisive piece of knowledge passes. Metaphor is rendered as architecture, and architecture as plot.

The Wachowskis have described their theme in exactly these spatial terms. The film, they said, concerns "the boxes people make of their lives," and closets are not inhabited by gay people alone; each character is defined by the particular trap he or she has built. They have also located the film's germ in an epistemological scenario: one sees a woman on the street, forms an assumption about her sexuality, and is wrong. The first statement is architectural and the second cognitive, and together they compress the film's entire problematic. A box is a bound. A wrong assumption is an act of knowledge that fails. Between the two lies the question this dissertation pursues: what follows when those whom a culture has boxed, and whom its

knowledge has misread, convert the box and the misreading into the instruments of their escape?

The Polysemy of the Bound

The title's single syllable gathers at least six senses, and the film activates every one. *Bound* is, first, the participle of *bind*: tied, restrained, held fast, as Corky is held in the closet and as Violet has been held by Caesar for five years. It names, second, the condition of obligation, of being duty-bound, bound by a promise, or bound over to a creditor; this is the register of the debt economy that destroys Shelly and of the promissory economy that preserves the women. It names, third, the state of being joined, the bond of lovers and of conspirators. It names, fourth, a direction of travel, the *bound for* of the open road onto which the final scene releases its couple. It names, fifth, a limit or boundary, the bounds of a property, and hence the wall between apartments. It names, sixth, a leap, and therefore the alternative ending the genre had recently offered such women in *Thelma & Louise* (1991): the bound into the canyon, frozen at its apex.

The fifth sense carries the heaviest philosophical freight. In the *Prolegomena* (1783, §57) Kant distinguishes a *Grenze*, a boundary that presupposes a space lying beyond it, from a *Schranke*, a limit that is mere negation. Hegel's rejoinder, developed in the *Science of Logic* and condensed in the *Encyclopaedia Logic* (§60), is that to determine something as a limit is already to have passed beyond it; a limit is known as such only from its other side. *Bound* stages this dialectic as domestic architecture. For Caesar, the wall between his apartment and the unit Corky is renovating is a *Schranke*, the edge of his property beyond which nothing that concerns him exists. For the women it is a *Grenze*, a boundary that presupposes, and indeed carries, a world on its far side. Sound passes through it; telephone calls pass around it; desire passes across it. The plot is the process by which a limit is converted into a boundary, and a boundary into a passage.

Thesis: Contraband Humanism

The argument of this dissertation is that *Bound* is a philosophically systematic text, organized around a theft whose object exceeds the money it nominally pursues. The humanist tradition transmitted its goods as a patrimony. Pico della Mirandola's dignity of self-fashioning, Montaigne's friendship of fused souls, Kant's emergence from tutelage, and the social contract's covenant of free and equal persons were each addressed, in their canonical formulations, to a subject who was male, propertied, and fraternal. Carole Pateman has shown that the contract tradition presupposes a prior sexual contract securing men's access to women. Jacques Derrida has shown that the philosophical discourse of friendship, from Aristotle through Montaigne to Nietzsche and Carl Schmitt, is a discourse of brotherhood that excludes the feminine twice, refusing both friendship between women and friendship between women and men. A good transmitted by inheritance can be acquired by the disinherited in only one way: by expropriation. *Bound* is the narrative form of that expropriation.

Three concepts organize the account. *Contraband* names the status of the goods: humanism's patrimony, smuggled across the boundaries (in Italian, the *bandi*, or decrees of ban) through which the human was constituted by exclusion. *Ligature* names the form of the bond the women build: a binding without bondage, horizontal rather than vertical, mutual rather than proprietary, constituted by knowledge rather than contract, and kept by promise rather than enforced by law. *Mētis*, the cunning intelligence that Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant reconstructed from Greek thought, names the mode in which the women act: oblique, adaptive, manual, attuned to opportunity, and native to the space of the more powerful.

A fourth figure, a chiasmus, describes the film's epistemological signature. Caesar possesses an *ignorant knowledge*: confident claims to know others that have never been tested against acquaintance. The women arrive at a *learned ignorance*, in Nicholas of Cusa's sense: a knowing refusal to fix the other within a category. The film's final exchange, in which the "difference" between the lovers is answered by a shared unknowing, resolves the chiasmus.

The thesis is stronger than the familiar claim that a heist allegorizes liberation, a reading that would leave the money a mere metaphor. Following Jean-Joseph Goux's demonstration that money, the father, the phallus, the

monarch, and the logos occupy homologous positions as "general equivalents" within their respective orders, I argue that the theft of Caesar's money and the theft of the humanist subject-position are not analogous acts but structurally identical ones. Caesar is the point at which every general equivalent in the film converges. To rob him is to rob them all at once.

Method: Nachträglichkeit and Reparative Reading

Criticism has long distrusted appeals to authorial intention, from W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's "The Intentional Fallacy" (1946) through Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) to Michel Foucault's analysis of the author-function (1969). The Wachowskis nonetheless present a distinctive hermeneutic case. Their lives as trans women, made public by Lana in 2012 and by Lilly in 2016 (the latter under pressure from a Daily Mail reporter who came to her door, as Chapter Six records), retroactively re-signify a film preoccupied with closets, boxes, disguises, and misreadings. Freud's term for such retroaction is *Nachträglichkeit*, the process by which a later experience confers meaning on an earlier trace that could not yet bear it; Jean Laplanche's *après-coup* refines the concept into a general theory of translation across time. This study treats the retroaction as a hermeneutic horizon in Hans-Georg Gadamer's sense, a fusion of the film's horizon with ours, and not as a biographical key. Chapter Six develops the discipline this requires.

The second methodological commitment derives from Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading" (1997). Sedgwick characterized paranoid criticism as anticipatory, reflexive, and mimetic, committed to a "strong theory" of negative affect and to exposure as a political act; against it she proposed a reparative practice that assembles and confers plenitude. In the case of *Bound* the distinction is not merely methodological, because the film contains its own paranoid reader. Caesar, whose characterization the directors modeled on Humphrey Bogart's gold-maddened Fred C. Dobbs, anticipates betrayal everywhere and is destroyed by the one betrayal his theory cannot conceive. A paranoid reading of *Bound*, exposing its traffic with the male gaze, its capitalist fantasy, and its whiteness, is necessary and is carried out in Chapter Seven. A reading that stopped there, however, would reproduce at the level of criticism the error the film diagnoses in its villain.

State of the Question

Bound screened at the Venice International Film Festival on 31 August 1996, after a January premiere at the Sundance Film Festival, and opened in the United States on 4 October. Its reception divided along lines that anticipate the arguments of this study. Mick LaSalle praised it as perhaps the first mainstream film to place a lesbian relationship at its heart without making homosexuality the plot's problem; Sarah Warn later called Corky the closest thing to a realistic and sympathetic butch lesbian yet seen in mainstream cinema. Emanuel Levy countered that the film had little to do with lesbian cinema at all. Todd McCarthy objected that love confers on the lovers no "privileged state of grace" excusing their conduct, and Rita Kempley dismissed the directors as imitators of the Coen brothers, a comparison to *Blood Simple* (1984) that recurs across the reviews. The film received the GLAAD Media Award for outstanding wide-release film in 1997 and has since acquired a durable cult following, particularly among queer audiences.

Scholarship has been thinner than the film's reputation. Mandy Merck's study of its classification documents the ratings board's particular anxiety over what Lana Wachowski called "hand-sex." Cáel M. Keegan's monograph situates the film within a career-long aesthetic of trans perception. B. Ruby Rich has addressed it within the history of New Queer Cinema and its mainstream afterlives. What has not been attempted is a systematic account connecting the film's economics, epistemology, ethics, and form to the humanist problematic, and measuring its achievement against the feminist and humanist canons it silently engages. This dissertation undertakes that account.

Architecture of the Argument

The chapters proceed from structure to agency to form. Chapter One analyzes the economy Caesar administers; Chapter Two, the knowledge on which his sovereignty rests and the ignorance that undoes it. Chapter Three theorizes the cunning by which the women act, and Chapter Four derives the ethics of their bond. Chapter Five examines how the film renovates the genre it inhabits, and Chapter Six reads it through the Wachowskis' later work. Chapter Seven tests the thesis against its rivals and its strongest objections.

Chapter Eight states the theory of contraband humanism in twelve theses, and a coda returns to the film's last words.

I

Chapter One

The House of the General Equivalent

Kinship, Capital, and the Laundering of Blood

Caesar's apartment is a machine for converting violence into value, and every relation inside it, from kinship to sex to money, is organized by the logic of the general equivalent. This chapter reconstructs that machine before the women dismantle it.

1.1 The Family as Kinship Machine

Claude Lévi-Strauss's *The Elementary Structures of Kinship* (1949) located the threshold between nature and culture in the incest prohibition, which he read not as a negative rule but as a positive obligation to exchange. Because a man may not keep his sisters and daughters, he must give them; because he gives them, he binds himself to other men in relations of alliance. Women are, in this account, the supreme gift, the medium through which men communicate. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975) turned this anthropology against itself. If women are the conduits of relationships among men rather than partners in them, kinship is not a neutral structure but a "sex/gender

system," the social apparatus by which biological sexuality is converted into gender hierarchy and compulsory heterosexuality. Rubin's synthesis of Lévi-Strauss, Freud, Lacan, Marx, and Engels made it possible to see the exchange of women and the accumulation of capital as interlocking economies.

The Mafia "Family" of *Bound* is an almost diagrammatic instance of the system Rubin described. Authority descends patrilineally from Gino Marzzone to his son Johnnie. Caesar occupies the structurally anxious position of the in-law of capital: indispensable to the Family's finances, excluded from its blood, dependent on the father's trust and exposed to the son's resentment. The hatred between Caesar and Johnnie, which Violet identifies as the lever of the heist, is overdetermined by this position; it is the rivalry of the adopted servant and the natural heir. Such a rivalry requires a medium, and the medium is Violet. When Johnnie flirts with her in Caesar's presence, the flirtation is addressed to Caesar, and the woman is merely the channel along which the insult travels. René Girard's *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (1961) called this structure triangular desire. Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) showed that the triangle's true axis runs between its two male points: a homosocial desire that must route itself through a woman in order to remain unacknowledged.

Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) supplies the political theory of the arrangement. The classical social contract narrates the passage from paternal to civil authority, but it conceals, Pateman argued, a prior sexual contract by which men secure orderly access to women. The modern order is therefore not post-patriarchal but "fraternal patriarchy": the brothers have overthrown the father, divided his powers, and preserved his privileges among themselves. Pateman found the founding myth of this order in Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913), where the sons of the primal horde murder the father and institute law and exogamy as a covenant among brothers. *Bound* restages the primal parricide as farce. Cornered by the disappearance of the money, Caesar kills the father, the son, and the father's bodyguard in his own living room. Nothing is founded by these murders. No covenant follows, the brothers do not assemble, and no law is instituted. The parricide produces only a vacuum, and into that vacuum the women's bond expands. The film's inheritance passes not down the fraternal line but sideways, to the sisters whom the fraternal contract had excluded.

The film's first image of its three principals proposes a different triangle from the homosocial one. In the elevator where Corky first sees Violet, Caesar stands beside Violet staring straight ahead while the two women exchange glances across him. The tableau is almost exactly that of Sappho's fragment 31, the founding text of lesbian lyric, in which the speaker watches a man seated opposite the beloved and is undone by what she sees, while the man remains godlike in his composure. Sappho calls him "equal to the gods" (*isos theoisin*). The epithet acquires an uncanny precision when the man's name is Caesar, the name Rome would divinize. The irony deepens when one recalls that the Latin poet who translated fragment 31 for Rome, Catullus, addressed his version (poem 51) to a woman he called Lesbia, and elsewhere aimed some of the most scurrilous verse in Latin at Julius Caesar himself. *Bound* superimposes two triangles. In the homosocial triangle, desire runs between men through a woman; in the Sapphic triangle, desire runs between women around a man. The plot is the war between these triangles, and its outcome is the destruction of the man who believed himself the apex of both.

1.2 Caesar as Condensation of the General Equivalent

In the first chapter of *Capital* (1867), Marx derived the money form through a sequence of value forms culminating in the general equivalent: a single commodity excluded from the world of commodities so that it may measure them all. Gold acquires its monetary function by standing apart, and its exclusion is the condition of its universality. In the essays collected as *Freud, Marx: économie et symbolique* (1973), later translated as *Symbolic Economies* (1990), Jean-Joseph Goux argued that this genetic structure recurs across apparently unrelated orders. The father occupies the position of general equivalent among subjects in the family, the phallus among objects of desire, the monarch among citizens, and language or the logos among signs. Each is a member of its set raised above the set to measure it, and each acquires its power through a constitutive exclusion.

Caesar is the point at which every general equivalent in *Bound* converges. He is the custodian of money in its purest function, since his labor consists in restoring dirty cash to equivalence, making it once more exchangeable for anything. His name is the name of the monarch, the proper noun that Western political vocabulary converted into a common noun for supreme rule (*Kaiser*, *tsar*). His gun is the film's phallus, the instrument through which he asserts

mastery in every crisis; during the filming of the late confrontation Gershon struck it from Pantoliano's hand with such force that she required stitches. He aspires to the place of the father, arbitrating the guilt of Gino's son before Gino himself and then eliminating both. He claims the logos: his last speech asserts that he knows Violet's mind, and his death refutes the assertion.

General equivalent	Order it measures	Theoretical source	Figuration in *Bound*	What the heist does to it
Money	Commodities	Marx, *Capital* I, ch. 1	The two million dollars Caesar launders	Expropriated and carried out of the Family's circuit
Monarch	Citizens	Goux; Kantorowicz, *The King's Two Bodies* (1957)	Caesar's name and his rule over the apartment	Ended by an intimate, as in Plutarch and Shakespeare
Father	Members of the family	Freud, *Totem and Taboo*; Pateman	Gino Marzzone, whose place Caesar usurps	Parodied in a parricide that founds nothing
Phallus	Objects of desire	Lacan; Goux	Caesar's gun and his sexual proprietorship	Disarmed, and named insufficient by Violet: "Everything you couldn't"
Logos	Signs and knowledge	Goux; Derrida	Caesar's claim to know Violet	Refuted by act: "Caesar, you don't know shit"

The directors' documented instruction to Pantoliano completes the portrait. They asked him to study Bogart's Fred C. Dobbs in *The Treasure of the Sierra Madre* (1948), American cinema's most celebrated study of the paranoia that gold induces in those who hold it. Dobbs, convinced that his partners mean to rob him, destroys the partnership that made the treasure possible, and the film ends with the gold dust for which he died blowing back into the mountains from which it was dug. Caesar is Dobbs relocated from the mine to the laundry. In both cases the general equivalent does not merely tempt its custodian; it remakes his epistemology, teaching him to read every other person as a rival claimant to the one thing that measures all things.

1.3 Laundering: Blood, Abstraction, and the Fetish

Near the end of the first volume of *Capital*, describing the epoch of primitive accumulation, Marx borrows a phrase from the journalist Marie Augier: money "comes into the world with a congenital blood-stain on one cheek," and capital "comes dripping from head to foot, from every pore, with blood and dirt." *Bound* literalizes the figure with a precision that approaches the didactic. The two million dollars Shelly embezzled return to Caesar's apartment soaked in Shelly's blood, and Caesar spends the night washing the bills, ironing them, and hanging them to dry on lines strung across his living room. The sequence is grotesque and domestic at once, and its domesticity is the point.

Marx's analysis of commodity fetishism holds that the social character of labor appears to producers as an objective property of its products: relations between people take on the fantastic form of relations between things. Laundering is the fetish made visible as labor. Its purpose is to erase from money every trace of the social relations, in this case the violence, through which it was obtained, so that it may reappear as pure, abstract, innocent value. The bill that leaves Caesar's ironing board says nothing about Shelly. The emperor Vespasian, rebuked for taxing urine, is reported by Suetonius to have held a coin from the first payment under his son's nose and asked whether it smelled (*Vespasian* 23). The maxim *pecunia non olet* records an imperial theory of money's indifference to its origins. Caesar's labor is the labor that makes the maxim true.

The film's iconography of washing joins a long Western sequence in which the cleansing of hands marks the disavowal of blood. Pontius Pilate, Caesar's governor, washes his hands before the crowd (Matthew 27:24). Lady Macbeth scrubs at a spot that will not come out (*Macbeth* 5.1). Most pointedly, Shakespeare's Brutus, having stabbed Caesar, bids the conspirators bathe their hands in Caesar's blood (*Julius Caesar* 3.1), converting the tyrant's blood into the insignia of liberty. *Bound* runs the sequence in both directions at once. Its Caesar washes others' blood from money so that the order he serves may disavow its violence. Its conspirators, at the end, shed his.

The scene's domesticity matters because washing, ironing, and line-drying are the archetypal forms of feminized and unwaged reproductive labor. Silvia Federici's *Wages Against Housework* (1975) argued that capital depends on this labor while refusing it the status of work; the household is where the

commodity world's purity is manufactured, invisibly, by women. In Caesar's apartment the gender of the labor is inverted, and the inversion is diagnostic. The man at the ironing board exposes what capital's cleanliness has always required: someone, somewhere, must do the washing. Violet's labor in the same apartment is of another kind. Jennifer Tilly has described how Violet's voice rises to a high, "girly" register whenever she addresses men, a performance that makes her seem vulnerable and ensures that she is looked after; with Corky it falls to its natural pitch. Arlie Russell Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983) named this emotional labor, the management of one's own feeling to produce a desired state in another. Caesar launders money. Violet, for five years, has laundered herself into the shape of his comfort.

1.4 Debt, Cruelty, and the Body of the Debtor

Shelly is the film's other thief, and his fate defines the economy the women must escape. Caught skimming, he is tortured in Caesar's bathroom by Caesar, Johnnie, and Mickey with their associates, while Corky and Violet listen through the wall: he is beaten and, as Roger Ebert's review describes the scene, faces the threat of having his fingers cut off one at a time. Johnnie then kills him, and his blood soaks the money. In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887), Nietzsche derived the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*), and located in the creditor-debtor relation the oldest relation between persons. The debtor pledged his body. If he defaulted, the creditor might inflict on it every kind of humiliation and torture, and Nietzsche cites the Roman Twelve Tables' indifference to whether creditors cut more or less from a debtor's body as evidence of how literal this equivalence once was. What the creditor received in compensation was, in Nietzsche's analysis, the pleasure of making suffer. The torture of Shelly is creditor-justice in exactly this archaic sense: a debt to the Family, paid in the body, extracted in the wet room where the household disposes of its waste. What the creditor threatens to take first is the thief's hand.

The title's pun on *bond* was anticipated four centuries earlier. In *The Merchant of Venice* (c. 1596–97), Shylock's surety is a pound of flesh, and his insistence on his "bond" makes the word the play's refrain. The bond is defeated by Portia, a woman in the disguise of a male doctor of law, who concedes the flesh and forbids the blood. The figure who outwits the debt

economy's claim on the body is a woman in masculine dress, and *Bound*'s Corky, in her work clothes and labrys tattoo, is her remote descendant.

Nietzsche's genealogy contains a further complication on which this dissertation will depend. The same essay opens with the task of breeding "an animal entitled to make promises," and argues that the capacity to promise was forged through a mnemotechnics of pain: humanity learned to remember its commitments because the failure to remember was punished on the body. In Nietzsche, promise and debt share a single bloody genealogy. *Bound* pulls them apart. The debt economy remains vertical, extractive, and cruel, as Shelly's death demonstrates. The women's promise, by contrast, is forged not by a creditor's cruelty but by pleasure exchanged between equals. The film proposes, in effect, an erotic rather than a punitive mnemotechnics, and Chapter Four develops what follows from it.

1.5 Commodities Among Themselves

Luce Irigaray's "Women on the Market" and "Commodities among Themselves," both collected in *This Sex Which Is Not One* (1977), read Lévi-Strauss through Marx. Women in patriarchal exchange are commodities whose value is conferred not by any intrinsic property but by circulation among men. A woman's body is accordingly split between a "natural" use value and a socially conferred exchange value, and Irigaray distributes the split across three roles: the mother as private property withdrawn from exchange, the virgin as pure exchange value, and the prostitute as use value that is itself exchanged. The economy as a whole is what Irigaray punningly called *hom(m)o-sexual*, since its real relations are those between men. Her essay closes on a speculative question: what would happen if the goods refused to go to market, and conducted among themselves a commerce that the dominant economy could register only as nonexistence or imitation?

Violet occupies none of Irigaray's three positions cleanly. She is neither wife nor mother. She is a kept woman, the moll, whose value is measured by Caesar's possession, Mickey's admiration, and Johnnie's taunting desire. Behind Caesar's back she has also been the lover of Shelly, the associate who skimmed the two million dollars, so that the commodity had begun to circulate on her own initiative before the heist began. *Bound* answers Irigaray's question with a narrative. The commodities do not merely refuse the market; they conspire, seize the general equivalent itself, and leave.

The argument has older roots in feminist economic thought. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Women and Economics* (1898) observed that humans are the only species in which the female depends on the male for food, and therefore the only species in which the sexual relation is also an economic one; she called the resulting arrangement the "sexuo-economic relation." Emma Goldman's "The Traffic in Women" (1910) insisted that the difference between the wife and the prostitute is one of degree rather than kind. Pierre-Joseph Proudhon furnishes the most instructive contradiction. The anarchist who declared in 1840 that property is theft (*la propriété, c'est le vol*) also held that a woman could be only a housewife or a harlot (*ménagère ou courtisane*). *Bound*'s two women, a convicted thief and a kept woman, turn Proudhon's first proposition against his second.

The moral calculus of the film is, however, older than Proudhon's. In *The City of God* (IV.4), Augustine asks what kingdoms are, once justice is removed, if not great robberies (*magna latrocinia*), and retells the story, preserved from Cicero, of the pirate who told Alexander that he was called a robber for doing with one small ship what the emperor did with a fleet. Corky served five years for theft, a crime she herself calls "redistribution of wealth." Caesar administers the finances of an organization that lives by extortion and murder. The heist is a small robbery perpetrated upon a great one, and the film's sympathies are Augustinian before they are anarchist: it declines to distinguish morally between the thief and the sovereign except by scale, and then reverses the usual distribution of sympathy that scale produces.

1.6 Chicago as Overdetermination

The film is set in Chicago, though it was shot over thirty-eight days in Santa Monica. The city is therefore a sign rather than a location, and as a sign it is overdetermined. The Wachowskis are Chicagoans who, before turning to comics and film, ran a house-painting and construction business there. Chicago signifies, first, the Outfit and the Capone legend, including the folk etymology that derives "money laundering" from gangland ownership of laundries; the term's documented currency dates from the Watergate era, but the folk story matters because it is the one the film literalizes. It signifies, second, the Chicago School of sociology, whose urban ecologies of crime, from Frederic Thrasher's *The Gang* (1927) to Clifford Shaw's *The Jack-Roller* (1930), treated criminality as a social formation rather than a moral failing.

It signifies, third, the Chicago School of economics, and in particular Gary Becker, whose "Crime and Punishment: An Economic Approach" (1968) modeled the criminal as a rational actor weighing expected gain against expected penalty, and whose "A Theory of Marriage" (1973) modeled marriage as a market in which partners trade complementary inputs to household production. *Bound* tests both models at once. Violet's five years with Caesar are a Beckerian marriage, her ornamental and emotional production exchanged for his income. Caesar reasons as *homo oeconomicus*, modeling every associate as a rational defector. The women's plan is rational in Becker's sense, since it predicts Caesar's reactions, but its decisive asset is one the model cannot price: a trust grounded in erotic knowledge. Its decisive miscalculation exposes the model's limit from the other side, because Caesar, as Chapter Two shows, is not a rational maximizer but a creature of Hobbesian glory.

Edwin Sutherland's *White Collar Crime* (1949), finally, defined a category of offense committed by persons of respectability in the course of their occupations. Caesar, the launderer in his suit, belongs to it; Corky, the convicted thief in her work clothes, does not. The film encodes class as the difference between kinds of crime, and it allies its sympathies, without sentimentality, with the kind that the law punishes most readily.

II

Chapter Two

The Epistemology of the Wall

Closets, Apparitions, and the Sovereign's Ignorance

Caesar's sovereignty rests on a claim to know, and the film's central demonstration is that this knowledge is structured by an ignorance it cannot perceive. The women prevail because they are, in a precise sense, unthinkable to him, and because they come to know by means he does not credit: listening, touch, and acquaintance.

2.1 The Closet as Opening Shot

Sedgwick's *Epistemology of the Closet* (1990) opens with the claim that many of the major nodes of thought and knowledge in twentieth-century Western culture are structured, indeed fractured, by a chronic crisis of homo/heterosexual definition. The closet, in her account, is not merely a hiding place but an epistemological regime: a structure in which the known and the secret are mutually constitutive, and in which ignorance is no simple absence of knowledge but a productive force with "ignorance effects" of its own. D. A. Miller's *The Novel and the Police* (1988) supplies the related concept

of the open secret, whose function is not to conceal knowledge but to conceal the knowledge of the knowledge.

Bound opens inside this regime. Its first shot, of Corky bound in Violet's closet, is a flash-forward, and its effect on a genre-literate spectator is to plant the expectation of feminine betrayal: a woman tied up in her lover's closet implies that the lover has turned on her or been destroyed. The film thus begins by making its audience share the noir epistemology it will spend the next two hours dismantling. In the opening minute the spectator is positioned where Caesar will stand at the end, confident of knowing what a woman like Violet will do. The film's later echo of the image is pointed. Violet tells Corky she had an image of her "inside of me," converting the closet's interior, a space of confinement, into the interior of a lover's body, a space of intimacy. The inside is not abolished; it is re-signified.

The Wachowskis' own gloss generalizes the closet beyond sexuality, insisting that gay people are not its only inhabitants. The universalization could be read as a dilution of the closet's specific history. It is better read as an extension of Sedgwick's argument. If the homo/heterosexual crisis structures knowledge in general, then everyone lives in some relation to the closet, and the decisive question is not who is inside it but who controls its door. The question is not merely figurative: in 2016 a newspaper reporter at Lilly Wachowski's door precipitated, by her account, her own coming out (Chapter Six). Caesar believes he controls the door. He is wrong about which door, and about which closet.

2.2 The Apparitional Lesbian and the Ring of Gyges

Terry Castle's *The Apparitional Lesbian* (1993) argued that Western culture has represented lesbian desire chiefly by derealizing it. The lesbian appears as a ghost, a specter, an absence in a crowded room, a figure "ghosted" so that she need not be seen. Monique Wittig's "The Straight Mind" (1980) supplies the epistemology that requires such ghosting. The heterosexual order produces a totalizing set of categories (man, woman, difference, the exchange of women) that present themselves as universal truths, and within which a lesbian can appear only as an error. Wittig's notorious conclusion in "One Is Not Born a Woman" (1981), that lesbians are not women, follows directly: "woman" names a position within the heterosexual system, and the lesbian is the one who has deserted it.

Bound treats this derealization as a resource. Preparing the role, Gershon drew on the account of a woman who had served time, and came to conceive of Corky as someone who would make herself invisible if she could. The skill that kept Corky alive in prison becomes, outside, the precondition of the heist. Caesar does not see the women because his categories contain no place in which to see them. He suspects Johnnie; he suspects Violet in league with Johnnie; he entertains every heterosexual and homosocial combination of betrayal. He does not imagine the lesbian couple until the plot forces it on him, and by then the money is gone.

Plato gave this situation its founding allegory. In the second book of the *Republic* (359c–360d), Glaucon tells of Gyges, a Lydian shepherd who finds a ring that renders him invisible, uses it to seduce the queen, kills the king with her help, and takes the throne. The story is a test case for justice: would anyone remain just who could act unseen? Herodotus (*Histories* 1.8–13) tells a different and sharper version. King Candaules, obsessed with his wife's beauty, compels his bodyguard Gyges to view her naked. She sees him, understands that her husband has made her a spectacle for another man, and offers Gyges a choice: kill Candaules and take the throne, or die. In Herodotus, the regicide is orchestrated by the woman whose body the king had displayed. *Bound* fuses both versions. Its women possess the ring of invisibility, and its woman displayed as a possession turns the display against her possessor. Unlike Plato's Gyges, however, they do not use their invisibility to seize the throne. They use it to leave the kingdom.

2.3 Caesar's Wife: The Bona Dea and the Sovereign Demand for Unsuspicion

The film's most precise classical intertext has gone unremarked. In December 62 BCE the rites of the Bona Dea, the Good Goddess, whose worship was reserved to women and from which men were strictly excluded, were celebrated at the house of Julius Caesar, then *pontifex maximus*. Publius Clodius Pulcher entered the house disguised as a female musician, reportedly in pursuit of Caesar's wife Pompeia, and was discovered. The scandal is recounted in Cicero's letters to Atticus and in Plutarch's *Life of Caesar* (9–10). Clodius was tried for sacrilege and acquitted. Caesar divorced Pompeia nonetheless, explaining, in Plutarch's report, that his wife ought not even to be

under suspicion. The proverb that Caesar's wife must be above suspicion descends from that answer.

The episode contains, in compressed form, the epistemological structure of *Bound*. There is a secret rite of women conducted inside Caesar's own house. There is a man who attempts to penetrate it in disguise and is exposed. And there is a sovereign whose concern is not the truth of what happened but the appearance of his wife's purity. Aristophanes had staged the Greek counterpart in *Thesmophoriazusae* (411 BCE), in which Euripides' kinsman, shaved and dressed as a woman, infiltrates the women-only Thesmophoria and is unmasked. Juvenal's sixth satire, for its part, imagines the Bona Dea rites as an orgy, furnishing the classical prototype of the male fantasy of what women do when men are absent. The tradition thus offers three male relations to the women's secret: the intruder (Clodius), the fantasist (Juvenal), and the sovereign who demands that the secret not exist (Caesar).

Bound's Caesar occupies all three positions, and his ruin follows from the third. What he requires of Violet is not fidelity but unsuspicion: the appearance, before the Family, of a woman wholly his. That appearance is precisely what saves the women. Mickey Malnato believes Violet's account of Caesar's flight because she is, to him, above suspicion. The sovereign demand that Caesar's woman be beyond doubt becomes the cover beneath which Caesar's woman destroys him.

In the year of the film's release, the social psychologists Peter Glick and Susan Fiske published their model of ambivalent sexism, distinguishing a hostile sexism of domination and contempt from a benevolent sexism of protection and idealization. Caesar embodies the first. Mickey, who wants Violet for himself and promises to find the man who wronged her, embodies the second. He is also one of the men who tortured Shelly in Caesar's bathroom: the film lodges the protective and the punitive faces of sexism in a single man. The two are complementary, and Violet survives by playing each against the other. Freud had described the underlying structure in 1912 as the splitting of the love object into an idealized figure and a degraded one ("On the Universal Tendency to Debasement in the Sphere of Love"). Violet passes between the two images, using the protection offered by the one to escape the possession exercised by the other.

When Caesar finally understands, his question is one of comprehension: what did Corky do to her? Violet's answer, "Everything you couldn't," joins the erotic and the epistemic in a single clause. The man who believed he

possessed her is told that there was an entire order of experience he could neither provide nor perceive.

2.4 Masquerade, Femme, and the Authenticity of the Performed

Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) described a patient, an accomplished intellectual woman, who after public displays of competence compulsively flirted with men, donning femininity as a mask to avert anticipated reprisal for having appropriated masculine authority. Riviere's most radical conclusion was that genuine womanliness and the masquerade could not be told apart: "they are the same thing." Violet's performance is Riviere's patient raised to strategy. Her high register with men, her apparent dimness, and her decorative helplessness are a masquerade worn to avert the reprisal of men who would destroy her if they understood her. Tilly herself identified with Violet as a woman underestimated by every man around her and obliged to play the game.

Mary Ann Doane's "Film and the Masquerade" (1982) extended Riviere to spectatorship, arguing that the masquerade's flaunting of femininity opens a distance between a woman and her image, rendering femininity legible as construction rather than nature. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) and "Imitation and Gender Insubordination" (1991) radicalized the point: gender is a repeated stylization without an original, and heterosexuality is itself a copy without an original. Sue-Ellen Case's "Toward a Butch-Femme Aesthetic" (1988) found in butch-femme role-play a camp theater of signs that exposes the constructedness of heterosexual gender while appropriating its erotic charge.

A purely constructivist reading nonetheless misses what the film insists on. Joan Nestle's essays on the femme, in *A Restricted Country* (1987) and the anthology *The Persistent Desire* (1992), defended the femme as a strong and desiring subject rather than a dupe of heterosexual codes, and named the suspicion with which femmes have been regarded within lesbian communities as insufficiently real. Julia Serano's *Whipping Girl* (2007) generalized the defense, arguing that feminist and queer theory alike have treated femininity as artificial, weak, or false, and that this devaluation is itself misogynist. Violet's femininity is not a disguise over a truer, unfeminine self. Away from Caesar, Susie Bright observed, Violet wears jeans and is less overtly feminine,

and her voice drops; but she remains femme. What changes is the register, not the identity.

The film's refusal of the dichotomy between authentic and performed femininity is the condition of its epistemology. The femme is legible in two codes at once. The straight mind reads her as Caesar's woman; the lesbian eye reads her as femme. She is the film's epistemic double agent, bilingual in a culture that presumes everyone speaks only one language. Corky's suspicion of Violet, which sustains much of the film's tension, dramatizes the intra-communal distrust Nestle described. When they first meet in the elevator, Corky takes Violet for a straight woman, so that the misreading on which the directors built the film is committed by the butch as well as by the straight man. When Corky later sees Shelly visiting Violet while Caesar is away, she suspects that Violet's desire for her is a con, and her past gives the fear its weight: a former partner, a woman, had double-crossed her. For much of the running time Violet remains a possible threat, the noir dame who may be playing an angle on a woman who plays straight. The genre and the community converge on the same question, whether her desire is real. The film answers yes, and makes the answer the condition of the heist's success.

2.5 The Acoustic Regime: Listening Against the Gaze

Martin Jay's *Downcast Eyes* (1993) traced the denigration of vision across twentieth-century French thought, from Bergson and Bataille through Sartre, Merleau-Ponty, Lacan, and Foucault to Irigaray, who argued in a 1978 interview that the eye, more than any other sense, objectifies and masters, and that its predominance has impoverished bodily relations. *Bound* is an anti-ocularcentric film made in an ocular medium. Its decisive knowledge travels laterally, through walls and wires, rather than vertically, through sight. Corky hears Violet and Caesar having sex through the building's thin walls. Both women hear Caesar, Johnnie, and Mickey torturing Shelly in the bathroom on the other side of the wall. During the climax, Corky waits in the adjoining apartment, listening to catastrophe unfold. The sound designer Dane Davis gave Corky a faint feline swish as she passed the camera, an acoustic signature that marks her as a creature of hearing and stealth.

Michel Chion's *The Voice in Cinema* (1982) defined the *acousmêtre* as a voice whose source is unseen, and attributed to it four powers: ubiquity, panopticism, omniscience, and omnipotence. Chion's examples (Mabuse, the

mother in *Psycho*, the Wizard of Oz) are mostly figures of patriarchal or monstrous authority. *Bound* redistributes acousmatic power. Its most elaborate deception is acoustic. With Mickey in the apartment, Violet calls the landline from the dead Johnnie's cell phone so that Caesar can feign a conversation with Gino, also dead, explaining that father and son are in hospital after a car accident. The women thus manufacture an acousmatic patriarch, a father who exists only as a voice on the line, and use him to send the Family's enforcer away. The paternal voice, which psychoanalysis made the bearer of the law, turns out to be something two women can ventriloquize.

Kaja Silverman's *The Acoustic Mirror* (1988) showed that classical cinema confines the female voice to the diegesis, binding it to a visible body and denying it the disembodied authority of voice-over. *Bound*'s women command both: the film opens on a voice-over, and its plot turns on voices detached from bodies. Avital Ronell's *The Telephone Book* (1989) read the telephone as a philosophical object, the apparatus through which the call, including Heidegger's call of conscience, arrives from elsewhere. Adriana Cavarero's *For More Than One Voice* (2003) argued that the voice bears the speaker's irreducible uniqueness. Tilly's voice, with its two registers, dramatizes that uniqueness under conditions of danger: one register for those who must be deceived, another for the one who must be trusted.

Two classics of apartment epistemology are thereby inverted. In Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954), knowledge comes from looking across a courtyard; in *Bound* it comes from listening through a wall. In Polanski's *Rosemary's Baby* (1968), the voices heard through the apartment wall belong to a conspiracy against a woman's body; in *Bound* they belong to a conspiracy of women against a man's dominion.

2.6 "Caesar, you don't know shit": The Paranoid Sovereign and the Death of Strong Theory

At the climax Violet holds Caesar at gunpoint, tells him that Mickey is on his way, and urges him to run. He refuses. His last argument is epistemological: she does not want to shoot him, and he knows she does not. Her reply, "Caesar, you don't know shit," precedes the shots that kill him. The sovereign dies of a knowledge claim.

Sedgwick's account of paranoid reading illuminates what fails. Paranoia anticipates, seeking to forestall bad surprises; it is a strong theory, able to

absorb any datum as confirmation; and it places its faith in exposure. Caesar is paranoid in exactly this sense, which is why the directors sent Pantoliano to Dobbs. He anticipates betrayal, absorbs every event into his theory of Johnnie's treachery, and stakes everything on unmasking the thief. His theory is strong enough to explain almost everything. What it cannot explain is the possibility its premises exclude a priori: that two women might desire each other enough to act in concert against him. His failure is not an excess of suspicion. It is suspicion organized by the straight mind.

In chapter 13 of *Leviathan* (1651), Thomas Hobbes identified "three principall causes of quarrell": competition, diffidence, and glory. Caesar is driven by all three, and the women's plan engages them unevenly. It exploits his diffidence, correctly predicting that he will suspect Johnnie. It assumes, however, that self-preservation will prevail over glory, and that Caesar, realizing he will be blamed, will flee. He does not. He reasons that flight would mark him as the thief and resolves instead to recover the money from Johnnie; at the end, offered flight a second time, he refuses again. The women's model of Caesar was therefore partly wrong. Their victory does not demonstrate omniscience. It demonstrates a capacity to adapt within a situation they did not wholly foresee, which is precisely the capacity the next chapter calls *mētis*.

The chiasmus announced in the Introduction can now be stated in its first form. Caesar possesses knowledge without acquaintance: he knows Violet as a type (the moll, the ornament) and believes the type exhausts the person. The women possess acquaintance that refuses to harden into typology. Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) argued that the highest knowledge of the infinite is a learned ignorance, a knowing of the limits of one's knowing. Caesar's ignorance is unlearned: it does not know that it does not know. The difference between the two is the difference between death and escape.

III

Chapter Three

Mētis and the Hand

Craft, Theft, and the Tactical Intelligence of the Bound

The women act through a form of intelligence that classical philosophy named, feminized, and subordinated: mētis*, the cunning of the weak, which works through the hand, the ear, and the opportune moment rather than through the sovereign gaze. This chapter reconstructs that intelligence, its genealogy, and its material instruments.*

3.1 Mētis Against Biē

Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant's *Les ruses de l'intelligence: la mètis des Grecs* (1974) reconstructed a form of intelligence that Greek philosophy, from Plato onward, largely excluded from its account of reason. *Mētis* is practical, oblique, and polymorphic. It operates in shifting, ambiguous situations that resist measurement; it seizes the *kairos*, the opportune moment; it binds and unbinds. Its emblems are the fox, the octopus with its shifting color and grasping arms, the hunter's net, the weaver's loom, and the navigator's art. Its paradigmatic human bearer is Odysseus, *polymētis*, "of many wiles," who defeats the Cyclops Polyphemus, a creature of pure force (*biē*), by naming

himself *Outis*, "Nobody," and so becoming unnameable to the one who would destroy him (*Odyssey* 9).

Two elements of this tradition bear directly on *Bound*. The first is the myth of Metis herself. In Hesiod's *Theogony* (886–900), Metis, goddess of cunning, is Zeus's first wife. Warned that she will bear a son destined to overthrow him, Zeus swallows her while she is pregnant, and Athena is later born from his head. The sovereign secures his rule by incorporating feminine intelligence into his own body, so that cunning becomes a property of sovereignty rather than a threat to it. Caesar keeps Violet inside his apartment as Zeus kept Metis inside himself: her intelligence is presumed to be his, contained and domesticated. The film is the story of Metis escaping the body that swallowed her.

The second element is the Odyssean name. The apparitional lesbian of Chapter Two is, in Greek terms, *Outis*. When Polyphemus cries out that Nobody is hurting him, his fellow Cyclopes conclude that there is no one to pursue. When Violet tells Mickey that Caesar fled with the money, the Family likewise concludes that there is no one to pursue but Caesar. The women occupy no position in the sovereign's categories from which they could be named, and their unnameability is their protection.

James C. Scott's *Seeing Like a State* (1998) adopted *mētis* as the name for the practical, local, experiential knowledge that high-modernist planning ignores at its peril. States simplify the world to make it legible, Scott argued, and their schemes fail when the simplifications erase the practical knowledge on which real practices depend. Caesar sees like a state: he counts, accounts, interrogates, and demands legibility. The women see like practitioners.

The film's plotting dramatizes the difference between *mētis* and mere planning. Corky devises a plan with the precision of a script. Caesar will shower after counting the money; Violet will drop a bottle of the scotch Gino favors and leave to replace it; Corky will slip in and take the money from the briefcase; Violet will return and mention having seen Johnnie leave. The plan predicts its target's reactions, and its central prediction fails. What succeeds is improvisation within the enemy's space: Violet's stalling bargain with Caesar, the counterfeit call from the dead father, Corky's disclosure that the money lies next door, which draws Caesar away and gives Violet her opening, and Violet's call to Mickey. *Mētis* is not the plan. It is the capacity to re-plan, continuously, from inside a situation one does not control.

3.2 Tactics, *La Perruque*, and Queer Use

Michel de Certeau's *The Practice of Everyday Life* (1980) distinguished strategies, the operations of a subject of will and power that possesses a proper place from which to manage an exterior, from tactics, the operations of those who have no proper place and must act within the space of another. A tactic plays on a terrain imposed on it and seizes opportunities on the wing; it is, in de Certeau's phrase, "an art of the weak." Among his examples is *la perruque*, "the wig": the worker's diversion of the employer's time, tools, and materials to her own ends under cover of doing the employer's work. Corky is hired to renovate the apartment next door to the Family's launderer. The job gives her access, tools, a pretext for presence, and a space suspended between owners and functions in which things can be hidden. The heist is *perruque* on a grand scale: the employer's building, the employer's hours, the employer's money, diverted under cover of the employer's job.

James C. Scott's *Domination and the Arts of Resistance* (1990) distinguished the "public transcript," the open interaction between subordinates and those who dominate them, from the "hidden transcript," the discourse that takes place offstage, beyond the direct observation of power. Violet's high register is public transcript. The conversations conducted through and around the wall are hidden transcript. The heist is the moment the hidden transcript is enacted, and the climax is the moment it is spoken aloud to power's face.

Sara Ahmed's *What's the Use?* (2019) proposed the concept of "queer use": the use of things for purposes other than those for which they were intended, or by those for whom they were not intended, emblematized by a postbox that birds have made into a nest. The renovation site, dust-sheeted and half-painted, is the film's laboratory of queer use. The adjoining apartment becomes a vault. A household telephone becomes a stage. A dead man's cell phone becomes the instrument of a counterfeit patriarch. The entire vocabulary of femininity becomes a cipher. Ahmed's earlier *Queer Phenomenology* (2006) described sexual orientation as a matter of how bodies are directed in space, of what is placed within reach and what is kept "in line," and read lesbian desire as a deviation that reorganizes the space it crosses. The film's choreography turns repeatedly on such deviations, glances that leave the line along which Caesar's look travels.

One qualification sharpens the argument. Audre Lorde warned that the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house, and Chapter Seven

weighs the film against that warning. Here it suffices to observe that Corky does not work only with the master's tools. She brings her own toolbox and her own truck into the master's house. The tools of her trade are hers, and the film's most consequential acts of cunning are performed with them.

3.3 The Thinking Hand

Susie Bright identified the hand as one of the film's specifically lesbian themes, the hand as sex organ, emphasized by lingering shots of Corky's and Violet's hands. The ratings board appears to have agreed on the hand's significance from the opposite direction: to secure an R rating the directors were obliged to cut part of the first sex scene, and the board's chief anxiety, as Mandy Merck has documented, concerned what Lana Wachowski called "hand-sex": images of manual sex between the two women. The censor's eye fixed on the very organ on which the film's sexual, economic, and epistemological orders all depend.

The hand has a philosophical history that the film's emphasis reopens. In the lectures published as *Was heißt Denken?* (1951–52), Heidegger argued that the hand is no mere grasping organ but the site of thinking itself: every motion of the hand, in every one of its works, is carried through the element of thought, and only a being that can speak, and therefore think, can have hands. Apes, he insisted, possess organs for grasping, but not hands. Derrida's "Geschlecht II: Heidegger's Hand" (1985) deconstructed this humanism of the hand, tracing how Heidegger's singular "hand" secures an abyssal difference between the human and the animal. Derrida's title word, *Geschlecht*, gathers sex, species, race, lineage, family, and generation into a single German noun. *Bound* is a film about *Geschlecht* in every one of these senses: sex, gender, the Family, the patrilineal line from Gino to Johnnie, the generational rivalry of father, son, and usurper, and the hand that thinks, steals, makes love, and fires a gun.

The Enlightenment located the hand's dignity in a masculine subject. In the *Observations on the Feeling of the Beautiful and Sublime* (1764), Kant remarked that a woman whose head is full of Greek, like Madame Dacier, or who conducts searching disputes about mechanics, like the Marquise du Châtelet, might as well also have a beard. Corky, painter and plumber, is Kant's bearded woman: a woman whose intelligence is mechanical and whose authority over materials is complete. In the drain scene, she assures Violet that

the problem need only be opened up, tinkered with, and fixed, and the camera holds her working hands in the foreground while Violet's legs and hips occupy the frame behind. The composition joins manual competence, erotic competence, and epistemic competence in a single image.

Jack Halberstam's *Female Masculinity* (1998) argued that masculinity detached from male bodies is not an imitation of men but an alternative masculinity, one that exposes how dominant masculinity depends on its own naturalization. Gershon built Corky from screen icons of male cool, citing James Dean, Marlon Brando, and Clint Eastwood. The citation is not mimicry. It demonstrates that the icons were themselves performances, and that the cool they embodied could be inhabited by someone those icons were never imagined to include. Gershon's own contribution to the character, the jaw harp Corky plays, is a small emblem of the synthesis: an instrument sounded by the mouth and plucked by the hand, uniting the film's two erotic organs.

Later fiction would make the alliance of theft, manual dexterity, and lesbian desire explicit. Sarah Waters's *Fingersmith* (2002) takes its title from Victorian slang for a thief, and Park Chan-wook's adaptation, *The Handmaiden* (2016), transposes its double con to colonial Korea; both end with two women escaping a patriarch's house with his wealth. *Bound* is their precursor in genre cinema. The film is also, in a biographical register that need not be overstated, a work of craft about craft. Before they made films, the Wachowskis ran a house-painting and construction business in Chicago. Corky's trade was theirs.

3.4 The Mechanics of Fluids

Irigaray's "The 'Mechanics' of Fluids" (1977) argued that Western rationality developed in complicity with a mechanics of solids, privileging what can be bounded, measured, and identified, and that it has consistently failed to theorize fluids, which resist formalization and the logic of identity. The feminine, in Irigaray's account, has occupied the place of the fluid that the phallic economy must either solidify or ignore. Bright's commentary on *Bound* reaches the same conclusion through practice. She called the film "wet" rather than "hard," feminine rather than masculine, and identified water as a recurrent motif representing women, beginning with the earring Corky retrieves from Violet's sink.

The film's fluids divide into two economies. Caesar's labor solidifies. He washes blood from money in order to restore bills to rigid equivalence, ironing them flat and pinning them in rows, a mechanics of solids applied to currency. Corky's labor opens circuits, clears blockages, and lets things flow. After she hears Violet and Caesar through the wall, the film cuts to Corky snaking years of hair and debris from a bathtub drain, the accumulated residue of a household's routine. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defined the abject as what the subject expels in order to secure its own boundaries; the drain is the domestic organ of abjection, and Corky is its custodian. Her very name is a plumbing term: a cork stops a flow, and pulling it releases one. Blood in this film is what must be washed away. Water is what carries desire.

The wall's surface completes the figure. In Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892), a woman confined by her physician husband to a single room becomes absorbed in the pattern of its paper, perceives a woman trapped behind it, and finally tears the paper from the walls, announcing "I've got out at last" as her husband faints across her path. Gilman's narrator escapes into madness. *Bound* rewrites the escape as fact. Its laborer is the one who prepares and paints the walls; its woman behind the wall gets out; and its husband, too, ends on the floor.

3.5 Lordship and Bondage; or, Odysseus Unbound

The section of Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) traditionally rendered in English as "Lordship and Bondage" (§§178–196) narrates a struggle for recognition between two self-consciousnesses. The one who risks death becomes lord; the one who clings to life becomes bondsman. The lord enjoys; the bondsman works. But the lord's independence proves dependent on a recognition that is worthless because it comes from an unfree consciousness, while the bondsman, through the fear of death and through formative labor on the object (*Bildung*), comes to recognize his own consciousness in the things he makes. Alexandre Kojève's lectures of the 1930s made this dialectic the hinge of modern thought. Simone de Beauvoir adapted it to sexual difference in *The Second Sex* (1949), with the crucial qualification that woman's situation is not that of the bondsman, since she has been excluded from the struggle altogether and positioned as the Other.

Bound distributes Hegel's positions with precision. Caesar is lord over Violet but bondsman to the Family, and his laundering is servile labor that yields no self-consciousness, because it erases rather than forms. Corky's labor is formative in the strict Hegelian sense: she repairs, paints, and reconstructs a habitable space, and her mastery of materials is the ground of her self-possession. Violet's labor is the most Hegelian of all. For five years she has produced the recognition that sustained Caesar's sense of sovereignty, and her freedom begins at the moment she withdraws it. The lord's truth, Hegel wrote, is the consciousness of the bondsman; Caesar's mastery was always on loan from Violet's performance, and when the loan is called in, it collapses.

Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) opens its first excursus with a different scene of binding. Odysseus has himself bound to the mast so that he may hear the Sirens without yielding, while his rowers, their ears stopped with wax, labor without hearing. Adorno and Horkheimer read the episode as the primal allegory of bourgeois society: the master enjoys art as powerless contemplation, the laborers produce without enjoyment, and self-binding becomes the prototype of a subject that dominates itself in order to dominate nature. The Sirens, it should be recalled, promise knowledge; in Homer they claim to know everything that happens on the earth.

Corky in the closet is Odysseus at the mast: bound, gagged, and hearing everything, unable to act on what she hears. But she is also the laborer, and her ears are not stopped. *Bound* collapses the Odyssean division of labor. The one who is bound is not the master but the worker. The worker hears. And the Siren, the feminine voice that in Homer lures men to their deaths with the promise of knowledge, is here neither lure nor danger but ally. Odysseus's binding preserves the order of enlightenment as domination. Corky's binding, imposed by the sovereign, is undone by the Siren herself, who returns with a gun.

IV

Chapter Four

The Ethics of the Ligature

Trust, Promise, and the Sapphic Solution to the Prisoner's Dilemma

Noir is the genre in which conspirators betray each other; Bound *is the noir in which they do not, and its ethics consists in explaining why. The answer, this chapter argues, is that erotic knowledge converts distrust into a trust that neither contract nor repetition can supply, and that this trust grounds a promise, a power, and a friendship the humanist tradition had reserved for brothers.*

4.1 Noir as Game Theory

The prisoner's dilemma was formulated in 1950 by Merrill Flood and Melvin Dresher at the RAND Corporation and given its canonical story by Albert W. Tucker. Two accomplices are interrogated separately, and each is offered leniency for testifying against the other. Whatever the other does, each does better by defecting; both therefore defect, and both end worse off than if they had trusted each other. The dilemma formalized a structure that crime fiction had been exploring for two decades. In James M. Cain's *The Postman Always*

Rings Twice (1934), the drifter Frank Chambers, hired to work at a roadside diner, conspires with the owner's wife, Cora, to murder her husband; after the killing, the law plays the lovers against each other, and their bond never recovers from the betrayals it extracts. In *Double Indemnity* (serialized 1936; filmed by Wilder in 1944), the conspiracy of Walter Neff and Phyllis Dietrichson ends with each shooting the other.

The structural rhyme between *Bound* and *Postman* is exact. A laborer is hired into a household where a woman is bound to a proprietor; the laborer and the woman become lovers; they conspire against the proprietor. *Bound* alters a single variable, the laborer's gender, and the alteration was contested. When studio executives read the script, some said they would be interested if Corky were rewritten as a man. The Wachowskis declined, observing that that movie had been made a million times. The refusal contains the film's thesis in nuce. The movie that has been made a million times is the movie whose couple defects.

Caesar plays the role Cain assigned to the prosecutor. Having discovered the theft, he ties both women up, threatens to torture them, and demands to know where the money is. This is the dilemma's interrogation scene, and its structure invites defection: either woman might buy her life by giving up the other. Neither does. Corky, moreover, has lost this game before. She tells Violet that she once had a partner, a woman, who double-crossed her ("I had a partner once. She fucked me."), and her five years in prison followed that betrayal. Her trust in Violet is extended against experience. Robert Axelrod's *The Evolution of Cooperation* (1984) showed that cooperation can emerge among self-interested agents when a game is repeated indefinitely, through strategies such as tit-for-tat. The heist, however, is a one-shot game, with no later rounds in which betrayal could be punished. What resolves the dilemma in *Bound* is not iteration but information of a particular kind: each woman knows the other's desire. Erotic knowledge is the information for which game theory has no variable.

Work	Conspirators	Target	Does the bond hold?	Outcome
The Postman Always Rings Twice (Cain, 1934; film 1946)	Frank Chambers and Cora	Cora's husband	No; legal pressure extracts betrayal	Cora killed in a car crash; Frank condemned for her death
Double Indemnity (Cain, 1936; Wilder, 1944)	Walter Neff and Phyllis Dietrichson	Phyllis's husband	No	Phyllis shot dead; Walter, wounded, confesses
Les Diaboliques (Clouzot, 1955)	Christina (wife) and Nicole (mistress)	Michel, the husband	No; the women's alliance is a ruse devised by Nicole and Michel	Christina dies of fright
Body Heat (Kasdan, 1981)	Ned Racine and Matty Walker	Matty's husband	No; Matty frames Ned	Ned imprisoned; Matty escapes with the money
Blood Simple (Coen, 1984)	Abby and Ray	None; the husband hires a killer against them	Corroded by mutual misreading	Ray killed; Abby survives alone
Thelma & Louise (Scott, 1991)	Thelma and Louise	None; flight from the law	Yes	Both die in the leap
The Last Seduction (Dahl, 1994)	Bridget Gregory, using Mike Swale	Bridget's husband	No; Mike is her instrument	Bridget escapes; Mike imprisoned
Bound (Wachowskis, 1996)	Corky and Violet	Caesar	Yes	Both survive and leave with the money

The table makes the film's singularity visible. Across six decades the genre and its neighbors offered three outcomes: the couple betrays itself, one partner uses the other, or the bond holds and the lovers die. *Bound* is the case in which the bond holds and both live.

4.2 The Erotic as Epistemology

Audre Lorde's "Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power" (1978) argued that the erotic is a resource of power and knowledge rooted in feeling, which patriarchal culture has suppressed, trivialized, or confused with the pornographic, the domain of sensation without feeling. Once recognized, the erotic supplies a measure of satisfaction and excellence against which other experience can be judged, and it builds a bridge between persons that lessens the threat of their difference. *Bound* places its central sex scene early, not as the culmination of a courtship but as the inauguration of a relation that the heist will test. The scene was shot as a single continuous take, the directors reasoning that duration would be more truthful than a montage of fragments. Mulvey identified the cut that fragments a woman's body as one of classical cinema's techniques for mastering it; the long take refuses dissection. Duration is the form of an ethic.

The film reactivates an archaic identity between sex and knowledge. In the Hebrew of Genesis 4:1, Adam "knew" Eve; the English idiom of carnal knowledge preserves the equation. Violet's two great retorts to Caesar are both claims about knowledge. He could not do what Corky did, and he does not know. The two judgments are one. The man without carnal knowledge of Violet is the man without knowledge of Violet.

Bertrand Russell's "Knowledge by Acquaintance and Knowledge by Description" (1910–11) distinguished what we know directly from what we know only through descriptions that apply to it. Caesar knows Violet by description: the moll, his woman, the woman who will not shoot. Corky knows her by acquaintance. The distinction acquires in *Bound* an erotic dimension Russell did not intend: acquaintance, here, is an intimacy that grounds a judgment of trust no description could warrant. Aristotle held that friends cannot know each other until they have eaten the proverbial salt together, that is, until long time has passed (*Nicomachean Ethics* VIII.3). The lovers of *Bound* have known each other for days. The film's wager is that erotic intensity under conditions of danger can compress the Aristotelian interval, producing in a night the knowledge that ordinarily takes years.

Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) described human beings as discontinuous creatures separated by an abyss, and eroticism as the substitution, for an instant, of continuity for that isolation. The Coda will read the lovers' final exchange as a Bataillean moment, with a decisive

qualification. Here it is enough to note that the film's erotics are also a politics. Susie Bright edited *On Our Backs*, the lesbian sex magazine founded in 1984 whose title mocked the radical-feminist newspaper *off our backs*, and she was a prominent voice on the pro-sex side of the feminist "sex wars," whose flashpoints included the 1982 Barnard conference "Towards a Politics of Sexuality," Gayle Rubin's "Thinking Sex" (1984), and the anti-pornography ordinances drafted by Andrea Dworkin and Catharine MacKinnon in Minneapolis (1983) and Indianapolis (1984). Bright joined the production in part because the script showed women unapologetically having and enjoying sex. Her choreography placed the film's erotic epistemology on one side of that war.

4.3 Promise, Power, and Violence

Nietzsche opened the second essay of the *Genealogy* with the paradoxical task nature set itself in the case of the human: to breed an animal entitled to make promises. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) made promising, together with forgiveness, one of the two faculties that redeem action from its predicaments. Forgiveness answers the irreversibility of what has been done; the promise answers the unpredictability of what is to come, setting up islands of security in the ocean of uncertainty that the future is by definition. The promise binds the future, and it is the only binding that is not domination, because it is undertaken by free agents in concert rather than imposed by a sovereign will. Caesar's world manages unpredictability by surveillance and terror. The women's world manages it by promise. Their promise has no notary, no creditor, and no Family to enforce it. It holds because it is kept.

Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguished power, which corresponds to the human capacity to act in concert and is never the property of an individual, from violence, which is instrumental and appears where power is in jeopardy. Violence, Arendt argued, can destroy power but is utterly incapable of creating it. Caesar's violence escalates in exact proportion to his loss of power. He kills Gino, Johnnie, and the bodyguard Roy; binds the women; threatens torture; assaults Corky. Each act is a confession that the obedience and recognition on which his position rested have collapsed. The women's power is the power of acting in concert. Violet's shooting of Caesar is the only lethal act the heroines commit, and it comes after she has warned him that Mickey is

coming and offered him flight. It is violence used to end a domination, not to found one.

In the first book of the *Republic* (351c–352d), Socrates argues that injustice breeds faction and hatred, so that not even a band of robbers and thieves can accomplish any common enterprise if its members wrong one another. The Family is internally unjust. Shelly skims from it, Johnnie and Caesar loathe each other, and the launderer murders the patriarch. It disintegrates in a single night. The women's band of two is internally just, and it succeeds. *Bound* literalizes the Socratic paradox. Honor among thieves is not a sentimental exception to the rule of injustice; it is the structural condition of any action in common, including theft.

4.4 Friendship Against Tyranny: Montaigne, La Boétie, and the Sister Excluded

Montaigne's "De l'amitié" (*Essais* I.28) describes his friendship with Étienne de La Boétie as a union in which souls mingle so entirely that they efface the seam that joined them and can no longer find it. Asked why he loved La Boétie, Montaigne could answer only *Par ce que c'estoit luy; par ce que c'estoit moy*: because it was he, because it was I. The same essay declares that women's ordinary capacity is inadequate to such communion, their souls not firm enough to bear the strain of so tight and durable a knot. The humanist canon's most celebrated friendship is premised on the exclusion of women.

La Boétie's *Discours de la servitude volontaire*, written around 1548 and published in 1576, argued that tyranny is sustained not by the tyrant's strength but by his subjects' consent. The tyrant has only the power they give him. Hence La Boétie's most famous sentence: *Soyez résolus de ne servir plus, et vous voilà libres*, resolve to serve no more, and you are free. The tyrant need not be fought; he need only no longer be served.

The pair gave Renaissance humanism two foundations at once: the friendship of fused souls and the critique of voluntary servitude. *Bound* joins the two in a single act and transfers them to women. Violet's resolution that she wants out, that she wants a new life, is La Boétie's resolution to serve no more. Her bond with Corky is Montaigne's friendship. In the film these are not sequential events but one gesture: the withdrawal of consent from the tyrant and the gift of oneself to the friend are the same movement seen from two sides.

Jacques Derrida's *Politiques de l'amitié* (1994) read the philosophical canon of friendship, from Aristotle and Cicero through Montaigne, Kant, Nietzsche, and Schmitt, as a discourse of fraternity, and identified within it a double exclusion of the feminine: the exclusion of friendship between women, and of friendship between a woman and a man. Derrida closed by asking what a politics of friendship might be if it were no longer modeled on brotherhood, and what place it might give the sister. Two years later, *Bound* answered the question in the vocabulary of genre cinema.

A qualification prepares the theory of Chapter Eight. Montaigne's effaced seam is a model of fusion, and so is the myth Aristophanes tells in Plato's *Symposium* (189c–193d), where lovers are halves of originally double beings (including, at 191e, female pairs whose halves seek women) and Hephaestus offers to weld them into one (192d–e). Fusion abolishes difference. *Bound*'s bond is better described as a ligature: as in typography, two letters joined in a single glyph without ceasing to be two. The ampersand itself began as a ligature of the Latin *et*. Corky *&* Violet.

4.5 Recognition and the Bonds of Love

Jessica Benjamin's *The Bonds of Love: Psychoanalysis, Feminism, and the Problem of Domination* (1988) located the origin of domination in the breakdown of mutual recognition: the failure to sustain the tension between asserting oneself and recognizing the other as an independent subject. Drawing on Hegel and on object-relations theory, and reading Pauline Réage's *Story of O* (1954) as an allegory of recognition sought through submission, Benjamin proposed intersubjectivity as the alternative, the capacity to recognize another as an equivalent center of experience while remaining oneself.

The film distributes Benjamin's categories with clarity. Caesar and Violet are a relation of domination: he requires her recognition while denying her subjectivity. Corky and Violet are a relation of mutual recognition sustained under extreme tension, first by Corky's suspicion and then by Caesar's interrogation. The title's sexual pun on bondage is resolved along the same line. The only non-consensual binding in the film is the sovereign's. Rubin's "Thinking Sex" mapped a hierarchy of sexual practices from a sanctioned "charmed circle" to the stigmatized "outer limits," and the lesbian sadomasochists of Samois, whose anthology *Coming to Power* appeared in 1981, insisted that consent is the line between binding as violence and binding

as pleasure. *Bound* never stages consensual bondage, but by assigning the only coercive binding to Caesar it draws the line exactly where Samois drew it. Binding as such is not the problem. Domination is.

4.6 The Femme Fatale as Kantian Problem

Kant's formula of humanity, in the *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785, 4:429), commands that one treat humanity, in one's own person and in that of any other, always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means. The femme fatale is the noir figure defined by her violation of this command. Phyllis Dietrichson's final confession, that she never loved Walter or anyone, discloses the truth the genre expects of her: the lover was only ever an instrument. *Bound* poses the question in the genre's own vocabulary. Is Violet using Corky? The partnership is plainly instrumental on both sides; each woman needs the other's capacities, Corky's craft and criminal expertise and Violet's access and performance. It is never merely instrumental. Kant's qualifier, *bloß*, "merely," is the hinge on which the film turns. The genre had always conflated instrumentality with betrayal; *Bound* separates them.

Simone de Beauvoir's *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) held that to will oneself free is also to will others free, and catalogued the failures of freedom that refuse this reciprocity: the sub-man, who flees freedom into apathy; the serious man, who subordinates freedom to an idol such as the Cause, the Nation, or Money; the nihilist; the adventurer, who loves action for its own sake and treats others as instruments; and the passionate man, fixed on a single object. Caesar is the serious man, whose idols are the Family and its money, and when the idol fails he turns nihilist, as Beauvoir predicted the serious man often does; the massacre in his living room is that turn. Mickey is the passionate man, fixed on Violet as an object. Corky begins as an adventurer, a professional thief for whom action justifies itself, and becomes free in Beauvoir's sense when her freedom becomes bound to Violet's. Beauvoir's ethics of ambiguity is, avant la lettre, an ethics of ligature: my freedom requires yours.

The chapter on "The Lesbian" in *The Second Sex* treated lesbianism as neither curse nor destiny but an attitude chosen in a situation. *Bound*'s opening voice-over speaks of choice, Violet tells Corky that "we make our own choices," and the film declines to decide whether Violet's desire for Corky is a discovery or a decision. The refusal is Beauvoirian. Tzvetan

Todorov's *Imperfect Garden* (1998) reduced the humanist tradition to three pillars: the autonomy of the *I*, the finality of the *you*, and the universality of *they*. *Bound* satisfies them in order. Violet's exit establishes autonomy; Corky's treatment as an end establishes finality; and the final refusal to name a difference between the lovers reaches toward universality, not by abstraction from particulars but by dissolving the hierarchy between two.

V

Chapter Five

Renovating Noir

Genre, Gaze, and the Architecture of Escape

Bound *does not reject noir; it renovates it, as Corky renovates the apartment next door, gutting what is rotten, preserving the load-bearing walls, and reorganizing the space for different inhabitants. This chapter examines the renovation at the levels of genre, look, image, sound, and ending.*

5.1 The Fatal Woman and the Absent Family

E. Ann Kaplan's anthology *Women in Film Noir* (1978) established the feminist analysis of the genre. Janey Place argued that noir's femmes fatales are typically destroyed or contained by their narratives, but that the films' visual style grants them a power that survives the endings: what audiences remember is not the punishment but the strong, sexual woman. Sylvia Harvey read noir as a genre of the absent or deformed family, in which marriage and domesticity are registered chiefly through their failure. Frank Krutnik's *In a Lonely Street* (1991) recast the genre as the symptom of a crisis in masculinity,

and Mary Ann Doane's *Femmes Fatales* (1991) argued that the fatal woman is not the subject of feminism but a symptom of male anxiety about it.

Bound converts each reading into a reversal. Place's split between narrative containment and visual power is closed: the strong, sexual woman is not punished, and her power survives the ending because the ending is a beginning. Harvey's absent family is replaced by a hyper-present one, the Family, which the film exposes as the deformed family par excellence; against it the lovers form what Kath Weston, in *Families We Choose* (1991), called chosen kinship, the networks that lesbians and gay men construct outside the bonds of blood. Krutnik's crisis of masculinity is personified in Caesar. Doane's symptom becomes a subject. The fatality survives, but it is redirected: Violet is fatal to the patriarch, not to her lover.

5.2 Genealogies of the Conspiring Couple

The film's documented lineage runs through Billy Wilder, whom the directors named as a major influence and whose *Double Indemnity* supplies the template of the conspiring couple; through Frank Miller's *Sin City* comics, which shaped the visual style; and through Huston's *Treasure of the Sierra Madre*, which shaped Caesar. Reviewers added the Coen brothers' *Blood Simple*, with its bloody comedy of a wife, a lover, a husband, and a hired killer misreading one another in confined spaces, and found echoes of Tarantino and Hitchcock.

Hitchcock's *Rope* (1948) is the more instructive Hitchcockian ancestor. It is set in a single apartment, where two young men coded as a couple and modeled on Leopold and Loeb murder a classmate, hide the body in a chest, and serve dinner from its lid; their former teacher exposes them, and the film ends to the sound of approaching sirens. The queer-coded criminals of the Production Code era had to be caught. *Bound* inherits *Rope*'s confinement and its body hidden in the furniture, the closet replacing the chest, and repeals its verdict.

Henri-Georges Clouzot's *Les Diaboliques* (1955) is the ancestor *Bound* most precisely inverts. A wife and a mistress, their intimacy charged with homoerotic undertone, conspire to drown the tyrannical husband they share; the film's twist reveals that the women's alliance was a trap laid by the mistress and the husband to kill the wife. Clouzot's lesson is that the bond between women was the illusion. *Bound*'s twist is that it was not.

The cinema of the early 1990s offered further narratives in which intimacy between women is the precondition of a crime that ends in confinement or death. Peter Jackson's *Heavenly Creatures* (1994) drew on the Parker–Hulme case of 1954, in which the teenagers Pauline Parker and Juliet Hulme killed Parker's mother, Honorah Rieper, to avoid being separated. Nancy Meckler's *Sister My Sister* (1994) drew on the case of the Papin sisters, Christine and Léa, domestic servants who in 1933 murdered their employer, Léonie Lancelin, and her daughter Geneviève at Le Mans, a crime Jacques Lacan analyzed that year in "Motifs du crime paranoïaque" and Jean Genet refracted in *Les Bonnes* (1947), where two maids rehearse the murder of Madame in ritual role-play and never leave the room. *Bound*'s women leave.

Paul Verhoeven's *Basic Instinct* (1992) cast a bisexual novelist as its suspected killer and drew protests from queer activists, among them members of Queer Nation and GLAAD, who objected to its depiction of lesbian and bisexual women as murderers. *Bound* answers the protest in the genre's own terms rather than by retreating into "positive images." Its lesbian protagonists are criminals, and the film is on their side.

Patricia Highsmith supplies the literary genealogy. *The Price of Salt* (1952), published under the pseudonym Claire Morgan, was remarkable in its era for permitting its two women a future together. *The Talented Mr. Ripley* (1955) gave popular fiction a criminal who escapes justice and whose escape the reader is invited to enjoy. *Bound* combines Highsmith's two scandals: the lesbian happy ending of the one and the unpunished criminal of the other.

5.3 The Gaze Redistributed

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) described classical cinema's division of labor, woman as image and man as bearer of the look, and identified two avenues by which the male unconscious escapes the castration anxiety the female image provokes. The first is sadistic voyeurism: investigating the woman, demystifying her, and then punishing or saving her. The second is fetishistic scopophilia: overvaluing her image until it becomes reassuring rather than dangerous.

Glick and Fiske's two sexisms map precisely onto Mulvey's two avenues. Caesar's hostile sexism takes the form of sadistic voyeurism; he investigates, interrogates, binds, and threatens. Mickey's benevolent sexism takes the form of fetishistic overvaluation; he idealizes Violet into an object of devotion.

Bound closes both avenues. The voyeur is killed and the fetishist is fooled. Neither mode of looking produces knowledge of Violet; both produce exactly the misrecognition she exploits. The film's primal scene of male looking is, once again, Herodotus's Candaules, who displays his wife to another man's eyes. Johnnie's flirtation with Violet, aimed at Caesar, reenacts the homosocial look that passes between men through a woman, and like Candaules's display it prepares the sovereign's fall.

Feminist film theory has long debated what a woman's look at another woman can be. Jackie Stacey's "Desperately Seeking Difference" (1987) examined films in which a woman's fascination with another woman mixes desire and identification. Teresa de Lauretis, in *The Practice of Love* (1994), objected that collapsing desire into identification desexualizes lesbian desire. Chris Straayer's *Deviant Eyes, Deviant Bodies* (1996) and Patricia White's *UnInvited* (1999) theorized the lesbian look and the conditions of its representability in mainstream cinema. *Bound* insists on the sexual. Its looks between women, from the elevator onward, are looks of desire, exchanged across a man who does not see them.

The film's relation to the "lesbian chic" of the 1990s, the mainstreaming of lesbian imagery for a largely heterosexual market, cannot be settled by its intentions. Many queer critics admired the sex scenes for their realism; others suspected titillation. The film's defenses are real: Bright's choreography, the refusal of fragmenting cuts, extras drawn from Bright's own community, and a ratings board whose anxiety fixed on hands, which suggests that the scenes were legible to the censor not as conventional spectacle but as something more disturbing, namely women's sexual competence. But Juvenal's problem, the male fantasist projecting onto the women's rite, cannot be legislated away; no film controls who watches it or how. Chapter Seven returns to the objection.

5.4 The Camera as Plumber

Bill Pope's cinematography, nominated for an Independent Spirit Award, drew on the stark contrasts of Miller's comics and on a mobile camera that glides along corridors, peers through apertures, and treats the building's walls as permeable. In one movement, as a reviewer has noted, the camera tracks along a telephone line and seems to catch in a knot: a ligature performed by the camera itself. The production record contains a detail that literalizes the argument of this dissertation. The central sex scene was shot as a single take

on what was supposed to be a closed set, and crew members moved the set's walls to allow the camera full movement around the actors. At the film's most intimate moment, the walls gave way.

The soundtrack performs a parallel renovation. Dane Davis's sound design gave Corky her feline swish; Don Davis composed the score; Zach Staenberg cut the film. The licensed songs re-voice the repertoire of heterosexual devotion: Aretha Franklin's "I Never Loved a Man (The Way I Love You)," Ray Charles's "Hallelujah I Love Her So," and, as the lovers depart, Tom Jones's "She's a Lady," a chivalric anthem by a heterosexual crooner reassigned, with irony and tenderness at once, to a couple of women. A track by the riot grrrl band The Hail Marys inserts the punk feminism of the decade into the mix.

Renovation is the film's aesthetic principle. The Wachowskis had earned their living painting and rebuilding houses, and their debut treats noir as a house to be renovated. The load-bearing elements remain: the moll, the mobster, the heist, the suitcase of money, the gun, the expectation of a double-cross, the chiaroscuro. The moral architecture is gutted: the punishment of the sexual woman, the couple's self-betrayal, the death of the queer. The studio executives who asked that Corky be rewritten as a man were asking, in effect, that the original floor plan be restored. The refusal was an architectural decision. The renovation also served as rehearsal: Pope, Staenberg, Don Davis, and Pantoliano all carried the experience into *The Matrix* three years later.

5.5 After the Celluloid Closet

Vito Russo's *The Celluloid Closet* (1981; revised 1987) catalogued Hollywood's representation of homosexuality, and its necrology, a long list of gay and lesbian characters killed off, documented the convention by which queer characters paid for their visibility with their lives. The Production Code had forbidden "sex perversion or any inference to it." The documentary adaptation of Russo's book by Rob Epstein and Jeffrey Friedman appeared in 1995, the year before *Bound*. The film arrived as an answer to the necrology: its queer characters are criminals, and they live.

The name of the film's femme carries its own history of censorship. Édouard Bourdet's play *La Prisonnière* (1926), staged on Broadway as *The Captive*, depicted a woman in thrall to an unseen female lover who sends her

bunches of violets. Police closed the production in 1927, and the episode helped prompt New York's Wales Padlock Law, which barred stage depictions of "sex degeneracy, or sex perversion." The violet was already associated with Sappho, whom Alcaeus addressed as "violet-haired" and whose fragments weave garlands of violets, and with the Parisian poet Renée Vivien, the "Muse of the Violets." It became a coded emblem of lesbian love; Andrea Weiss titled her history of lesbians in cinema *Vampires and Violets* (1992). Whether or not the Wachowskis intended the allusion, a femme named Violet who conspires with a woman against her keeper inherits the code.

B. Ruby Rich's 1992 essay in *Sight & Sound* named the New Queer Cinema, whose films included Todd Haynes's *Poison* (1991), Tom Kalin's *Swoon* (1992), a revisionist telling of the Leopold and Loeb case, and Gregg Araki's *The Living End* (1992), a road movie of two HIV-positive men on the run. The movement rejected the politics of positive images in favor of queer criminality, rage, and style. Lesbian filmmaking of the same years included Donna Deitch's *Desert Hearts* (1985), Rose Troche's *Go Fish* (1994), set in Chicago, Maria Maggenti's *The Incredibly True Adventure of Two Girls in Love* (1995), and Cheryl Dunye's *The Watermelon Woman* (1996). *Bound* translates the New Queer refusal into a commercial genre. It is a studio-scale thriller in which lesbian identity is neither the problem of the plot nor its solution but the condition of its intelligence. The GLAAD Media Award it received in 1997 recognized, in effect, that a film need not be about the closet to be an answer to it.

5.6 The Bound and the Leap: Endings

Thelma & Louise (1991), directed by Ridley Scott from Callie Khouri's screenplay, ends with its two women, pursued by the police, driving off the rim of the Grand Canyon; the image freezes in midair and fades to white. The leap is sublime and terminal, freedom figured as the instant before death. *Bound*'s ending enacts the other sense of its title. Not the bound into the canyon, but being bound for somewhere: a departure along a road. Mickey offers Violet his protection and his affection; she declines, telling him that she needs a clean break, and leaves hand in hand with Corky while Tom Jones sings.

Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) cast queerness as the figure of the death drive, refusing the "reproductive futurism" organized around the figure of the Child. Noir, with its fatalism and its fixation on death, is a genre of no future, and *Thelma & Louise* is its feminist apotheosis. José Esteban Muñoz's *Cruising Utopia* (2009) answered Edelman by defining queerness as a horizon, something not yet here, drawing on Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* and its category of the not-yet-conscious. *Bound* grafts futurity onto noir without reproductive futurism. There is no child, no marriage, and no house: only a stolen fortune, a truck, and a road. Its future is Muñozian, a horizon rather than a destination. What the lovers say to each other as they leave is reserved for the Coda.

VI

Chapter Six

The Body Unbound

Trans Hermeneutics and the Wachowskian Corpus

Read after the fact, Bound *becomes the first statement of a problem the Wachowskis' cinema would pursue for a quarter century: how a body bound by a system escapes it, and what kind of bond makes the escape possible. This chapter reads that trajectory under the discipline of* Nachträglichkeit.

6.1 Nachträglichkeit and Its Discipline

Freud's concept of *Nachträglichkeit* runs from the *Project for a Scientific Psychology* (1895), where a later scene confers traumatic meaning on an earlier one, to the Wolf Man case (1918), where a primal scene is understood only belatedly. Jean Laplanche's elaboration of the *après-coup* treats meaning as a translation that runs in both temporal directions: the earlier trace is not merely interpreted by the later event but becomes, through it, what it was always capable of meaning. The concept is apt for authorship as well as for symptoms. The Wachowskis made *Bound* years before Lana made her transition public in 2012 and Lilly made hers public in March 2016. Lilly's

statement, published by Chicago's Windy City Times, was prompted by a Daily Mail reporter who came to her door seeking an interview about her transition. She described it as her answer to an outing threatened against her will, and recalled the paper's part, as she put it, in the public outing of Lucy Meadows, a British trans schoolteacher who died by suicide in 2013, three months after a Mail column attacked her. The paper denied coercing Wachowski and denied responsibility for Meadows's outing. In 2020 Lilly stated publicly that the trans reading of *The Matrix* reflected the film's original intention. Cáel M. Keegan's *Lana and Lilly Wachowski* (2018) reads their cinema as an aesthetics of trans perception, a cinema that seeks to make the spectator sense transformation rather than merely see it.

Three disciplines govern the reading that follows. The first forbids biographical decoding. Corky and Violet are not ciphers for their makers, and the film's lesbian characters are not a disguise for some other identity; to read them so would repeat, at the level of criticism, the very misreading the film punishes. The second requires that every claim rest on figures the film itself supplies: the closet, the box, the misreading on sight, the performance that survives by being underestimated. The third treats retroaction as productive rather than revelatory. Later lives do not uncover a hidden meaning in the film; they enlarge the horizon within which its meanings can be heard. It bears noting that the directors' own statements from the 1990s already pointed outward. They universalized the closet, and they located the film's origin in the experience of misreading a woman's sexuality on sight, a scenario that trans experience knows from both sides.

6.2 Passing, Visibility, and the Ethics of the Tactical Self

Sandy Stone's "The Empire Strikes Back: A Posttranssexual Manifesto" (written 1987, published 1991) criticized the medical and cultural imperative that trans people "pass" and erase their histories, and called for a practice of reading oneself aloud. *Bound*'s two heroines figure two relations to passing. Violet passes, as straight, as Caesar's woman, and as the decorative moll, and her passing is tactical rather than constitutive. Corky does not pass and could not if she wished; her visibility, from the labrys to the leather to the walk, is at once her danger and her dignity. The film validates passing as tactic without making it an identity, and its ending is a scene of visibility: two women

leaving hand in hand before a mobster who does not understand what he is seeing. Tactical passing serves an eventually visible life.

Julia Serano has argued that the vocabulary of "passing" casts trans people as deceivers, and that the cultural figure of the deceptive woman, whose true nature is exposed and punished, is a staple of trans-misogynist narrative. Noir's femme fatale belongs to the same family of figures: the woman whose appearance conceals a truth that the plot must expose. *Bound* inverts the structure. The woman whose appearance misleads is not exposed and punished. The man who misreads her is.

Susan Stryker's "My Words to Victor Frankenstein Above the Village of Chamounix: Performing Transgender Rage" (1994) took the voice of Frankenstein's creature, made monstrous by its maker and by the world, and turned it back against the maker in rage. The structural analogy illuminates Caesar's final claim. "I know you" is the claim of a maker who believes he has fashioned Violet into what she is, the kept woman he furnished, dressed, and taught to speak in a certain register, and who therefore believes he knows her as a craftsman knows his work. Violet's reply is the creature's rejoinder. The analogy is structural, not an identity claim: Violet is not a trans character. But the form of the rejoinder, a made thing answering its maker's claim to know it, is one the Wachowskis would return to again and again.

6.3 Through the Wall: From *Bound* to *The Matrix*, *V for Vendetta*, *Cloud Atlas*, and *Sense8*

The Matrix (1999) relocates the bound body to the pod, and the sovereign's enforcers to the Agents of a simulated order; its red pill is an exit. Its first meeting between Neo and Trinity turns on a misreading of gender, when Neo admits he had assumed Trinity was a man and she replies that most men do. Caesar's error reappears as Neo's, with the difference that Neo is corrected and learns. Joe Pantoliano's two roles for the Wachowskis form a diptych. As Caesar he is the sovereign who refuses the exit; as Cypher, the traitor of *The Matrix*, he is the man who wants to be reinserted into the illusion. Both prefer a comfortable misrecognition to an uncomfortable truth.

V for Vendetta (2005), which the Wachowskis wrote from Alan Moore and David Lloyd's graphic novel for James McTeigue to direct, contains the oeuvre's most direct restatement of *Bound*'s central figure. Valerie, an actress imprisoned and killed by the fascist Norsefire regime for being a lesbian,

writes the story of her life on toilet paper and passes it through a hole in the wall of her cell, where it reaches Evey and transforms her. A woman's voice passes through a wall to another woman. In *Bound* the wall belonged to a mobster's apartment; in *V for Vendetta* it belongs to a state prison; in both, the message that crosses it makes the recipient free.

Cloud Atlas (2012), made with Tom Tykwer from David Mitchell's novel, contains the oeuvre's most explicit gloss on the earlier film's title. Sonmi-451, a fabricated server, a manufactured person sold as a commodity, becomes a revolutionary and declares that our lives are not our own, that we are bound to others, past and present. Irigaray's commodity that refuses the market recurs as a science-fiction heroine, and the dyadic bond of *Bound* is expanded into a metaphysics of connection across centuries. The film's practice of casting actors across racial lines through makeup drew sustained criticism: the Media Action Network for Asian Americans condemned as yellowface the prosthetic makeup that turned white actors, among them Jim Sturgess and Hugo Weaving, into Korean characters in the Neo Seoul story, and the exclusion of Asian actors from that story's leading roles. The oeuvre's universalism has its own blind spots, as Chapter Seven argues of *Bound*.

Sense8 (2015–2018), created with J. Michael Straczynski, links eight strangers across continents into a shared sensorium. Among them is Nomi Marks, a trans woman played by the trans actress Jamie Clayton, whose girlfriend Amanita helps her escape a hospital where she is to be subjected to an unwanted brain operation: a lesbian couple's escape from institutional capture, two decades after Corky and Violet's escape from criminal capture. The series' tagline, "I am also a we," generalizes the ligature. The dyad becomes a cluster, and the wall between persons becomes permeable to sensation itself.

The Matrix Resurrections (2021), directed by Lana Wachowski, closes the circle with two gestures. Its trailer included a background sign for "Corky's Massage Spa & Salon" bearing a labrys, an explicit citation of the debut. And at its climax it is Trinity, not Neo, who flies. In French the verb *voler* means both to steal and to fly, a pun on which Hélène Cixous built a feminist theory of writing (Chapter Seven). The arc from *Bound* to *Resurrections* runs from the first sense of the word to the second.

6.4 Humanism, Posthumanism, and the Bound Body

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) offered the cyborg as a post-gender figure that refuses organic wholeness and origin stories. Rosi Braidotti's *Nomadic Subjects* (1994) and *The Posthuman* (2013) theorized a subjectivity of movement and relation beyond the unitary humanist self. Sylvia Wynter's "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom" (2003) argued that a particular, Western, bourgeois genre of the human, which she called "Man," has overrepresented itself as the human as such. The Wachowskian corpus moves across these positions, from the human dyad toward networks, simulations, fabricated persons, and collective sensoria. It moves, in other words, from humanism toward posthumanism.

Bound is the humanist pole of that trajectory. Its stakes are two bodies, a wall, a gun, and a road. But its humanism is already contraband: it claims the goods of the human for those whom "Man" excluded. Wynter's pun on genre is apt. *Bound* changes the genre of a film, and in doing so proposes a different genre of the human, one in which the self-fashioning subject is a butch ex-convict and a femme who refuses to be owned. Wynter's critique also marks the limit of that proposal, because the re-genred human of *Bound* is still white, and the next chapter takes up that limit directly.

VII

Chapter Seven

Comparative Horizons and the Limits of the Heist

Measured against the humanist and feminist canons, Bound *claims their goods while exposing the exclusions through which those goods were distributed. Measured against its strongest objections, its achievement proves real and its limits structural. This chapter conducts both measurements.*

7.1 The Humanist Canon and Its Exclusions

Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) imagines God placing Adam at the center of the world without a fixed seat, form, or function, so that he may fashion himself in whatever shape he prefers. The human is the chameleon, the self-fashioning animal. Stephen Greenblatt's *Renaissance Self-Fashioning* (1980) showed that such fashioning was always conducted within and against structures of power. Violet's voice, which changes register with its audience, is chameleonic in Pico's sense, but until the heist her self-fashioning was conducted entirely for the benefit of others. The film turns at the moment self-fashioning becomes self-possession.

Kant's "An Answer to the Question: What Is Enlightenment?" (1784) defines enlightenment as humanity's emergence from its self-incurred immaturity (*Unmündigkeit*), the inability to use one's own understanding without another's guidance, and adopts *sapere aude* as its motto. Kant blames the guardians who, having made their domesticated cattle docile, warn them of the dangers of walking alone, and he observes that by far the greater part of humanity, including the entire fair sex, regards the step toward maturity as dangerous. The essay names women among the immature and attributes their immaturity to their guardians. Violet's five years are a case study in tutelage: a guardian who houses her, dresses her, and speaks for her, and who has persuaded everyone around her, and for a time Violet herself, that walking alone is dangerous. Her emergence is Kantian Enlightenment conducted against Kant's own expectations of the fair sex.

Mary Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) extended Enlightenment reason to women against Rousseau's *Émile* (1762), whose fifth book prescribes for Sophie an education wholly relative to men. Its most famous image is precise for *Bound*: "Taught from their infancy that beauty is woman's sceptre, the mind shapes itself to the body, and, roaming round its gilt cage, only seeks to adorn its prison." Violet's apartment is the gilt cage. The span of Corky's incarceration, five years, is also the span of Violet's years with Caesar, and the film sets the gilt cage beside the penitentiary as two forms of a single confinement. John Stuart Mill's *The Subjection of Women* (1869), shaped by his collaboration with Harriet Taylor Mill, described the legal condition of the wife as a bondage that in certain respects exceeded that of the slave. The word the law used was the film's title: the wife was bound.

Edward Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004) defended humanism not as a canon to be revered but as a critical practice that exposes the exclusions committed in its name. Martha Nussbaum's *Women and Human Development* (2000) specified a list of central human capabilities, among them bodily integrity, affiliation, and control over one's material and political environment. Violet lacks all three when the film begins and holds all three when it ends; she acquires them by theft. Nussbaum's capabilities are meant to be secured by just institutions. *Bound* depicts their acquisition where the institutions are the problem.

The twentieth century's quarrel over humanism provides the final coordinate. Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1947) rejected humanism as the metaphysical determination of a human essence. Sartre's "Existentialism Is

a Humanism" (1946) defended a humanism without essence, in which existence precedes essence. Foucault's *The Order of Things* (1966) predicted that "man," a recent invention, would be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. *Bound* stands outside this quarrel. Its humanism concerns goods, not essences: not what the human is, but what the human has been permitted to have, and by whom.

7.2 Feminist Genealogies: Money, Rooms, Walls

Virginia Woolf's *A Room of One's Own* (1929) argued that a woman must have money and a room of her own if she is to write fiction. Its most celebrated passage imagines a novel in which "Chloe liked Olivia," and observes that women in literature had almost always been shown in relation to men; Chloe and Olivia share a laboratory. *Bound* is genre cinema's "Chloe liked Olivia": two women seen in relation to each other, sharing not a laboratory but a heist. Its material conditions are exactly Woolf's: money, and a room, first the apartment next door and then the cab of a truck. Woolf's *Three Guineas* (1938) imagined a Society of Outsiders who would refuse the institutions of patriarchy from the professions to the nation, declaring that as a woman she had no country. Corky and Violet form a society of outsiders with two members, and they refuse the Family.

Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* (1963) named the gilded confinement of the postwar housewife "the problem that has no name." As president of the National Organization for Women, Friedan later described lesbians as a "lavender menace" to the movement's respectability, and in 1970 the Radicalesbians answered with the manifesto "The Woman-Identified Woman," which defined the lesbian as the rage of all women condensed to the point of explosion. A femme named Violet, kept in a gilded apartment, who becomes the agent of a man's destruction, is a lavender menace in the gilt cage.

Adrienne Rich's "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence" (1980) analyzed heterosexuality as a political institution enforced through economic dependence, violence, and erasure, and proposed a "lesbian continuum" of woman-identified experience. Critics including de Lauretis and Rubin objected that the continuum desexualized lesbianism by folding it into female bonding. *Bound* keeps Rich's political claim, since Violet's heterosexual life is economically compelled, and refuses the desexualization. Monique

Wittig went further. In "One Is Not Born a Woman" she compared lesbians to runaway slaves escaping the class that held them, and *Les Guérillères* (1969) imagined women at war with the categories of patriarchal language. The film's final departure is Wittigian fugitivity: the women do not overthrow the Family; they desert it.

Audre Lorde's "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House" (1979), delivered to a feminist conference that had marginalized Black women and lesbians, argued that the master's tools may allow us temporarily to beat him at his own game but will never bring about genuine change. Lorde asked that difference be understood not as a threat to be tolerated but as a reservoir of creative polarities. The distinction between beating the master at his game and changing the house is the exact measure of *Bound*'s achievement and its limit. The women beat Caesar at his own game, deception, theft, and the gun, and they leave the master's house standing behind them.

Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) called women to write their bodies, and built one of its most memorable passages on the double sense of the French *voler*, to fly and to steal. Women, Cixous wrote, take after birds and robbers; they jumble the order of space, rearrange the furniture, dislocate things and values, and empty structures. The passage reads as a description of *Bound* written two decades in advance: a heist conducted by a woman who renovates apartments for a living, emptying a structure of its value and rearranging its contents. Cixous's essay "Sorties," in *La Jeune Née* (1975) with Catherine Clément, catalogued the hierarchical oppositions of Western thought (activity and passivity, culture and nature, head and heart, logos and pathos) and sought ways out. *Bound* is a film of sorties.

bell hooks's "The Oppositional Gaze: Black Female Spectators" (1992) criticized feminist film theory for universalizing the white woman as the object and subject of the cinematic look, and described the critical, oppositional looking that Black women spectators developed in response. *Bound*'s spectatorial politics, analyzed in Chapter Five, belong to the tradition hooks criticized. Its lesbian gaze is a gaze between white women.

7.3 Sapphic and Criminal Precedents

Sappho's first fragment, the Hymn to Aphrodite, ends by asking the goddess to be the poet's *symmachos*, her ally in battle. The erotic is figured as alliance. Aristophanes' *Lysistrata* (411 BCE) supplies the classical precedent for women seizing the treasury: the older women occupy the Acropolis, where Athens kept its funds, to cut off the money for the war. Lysistrata's women return the treasury when peace is made. *Bound*'s women keep it.

The Book of Judith tells of a widow who enters the camp of the Assyrian general Holofernes, beguiles him, and beheads him as he lies drunk, with her maidservant at hand. Artemisia Gentileschi painted the scene twice, around 1612–13 and around 1620, showing the maidservant actively pinning Holofernes down, two women laboring together to kill a tyrant, where Caravaggio's earlier version had shown an aged servant watching. Gentileschi's canvases have often been read in light of her rape by Agostino Tassi and the trial of 1612. *Bound*'s climax is Gentileschian: Corky grapples with Caesar, and Violet kills him. Aeschylus' *Oresteia* (458 BCE) shows what usually follows a woman's killing of a sovereign: Clytemnestra kills Agamemnon, her son Orestes avenges his father, and Athena's court acquits him after Apollo argues that the mother is not the true parent of the child. The trilogy ends by founding a patriarchal court. *Bound* refuses the Oresteian sequel. The son is already dead, and the Family's enforcer has been deceived.

The modern lesbian novel supplied the template *Bound* refuses. Radclyffe Hall's *The Well of Loneliness* (1928), suppressed in Britain after an obscenity trial, made the "invert" Stephen Gordon a figure of noble suffering. Ann Bannon's pulp novels of 1957–1962 gave midcentury readers the butch Beebo Brinker, and Jane Rule's *Desert of the Heart* (1964) one of the period's rare hopeful endings. The later fiction that most resembles *Bound*, Sarah Waters's *Fingersmith* and its adaptations, and Todd Haynes's *Carol* (2015), from Highsmith's *The Price of Salt*, confirms that the film's refusal of tragedy became, in time, a tradition.

The sharpest comparison lies in the same autumn. F. Gary Gray's *Set It Off* (1996), released a month after *Bound*, follows four Black women in Los Angeles who turn to robbing banks after Frankie is fired from her teller's job on suspicion following a robbery, after the police shoot dead Stony's younger brother Stevie, mistaking him for a robber, and after child protective services take T.T.'s son. Three of them die. A bank security guard shoots T.T. during

the final robbery; the police shoot Frankie as she tries to escape, and kill Cleo, the group's butch lesbian, played by Queen Latifah, after she drives through a police barricade. Only Stony escapes, and she escapes alone. In a single season, American cinema produced two films about women who rob to escape. The white lesbian couple leaves together with the money. The Black butch lesbian dies in a spectacle of state violence. The distribution of narrative survival follows the color line.

7.4 Objections

The neoliberal objection. Nancy Fraser's "Feminism, Capitalism and the Cunning of History" (2009) argued that second-wave feminism's critiques of the family wage and of state paternalism were resignified, in the decades after 1980, to legitimate a new, flexible capitalism, so that the feminist ideal of autonomy became the ideal of the entrepreneurial self. *Bound* appears in the decade Fraser analyzed, and its heroines' emancipation coincides with private acquisition. The two million dollars are not redistributed; one could call the film an entrepreneurial fantasy before the fact. The objection must be granted in part. But the film does not present the theft as redistribution. It presents it as exit. The money remains marked, since the audience has watched it washed of blood, and the women's theft does not launder it a second time. The ending's irony keeps the happy ending in quotation marks. Above all, contraband humanism is honest about the compromised status of what it seizes. Within capital, exit takes the form of expropriation, and stolen goods remain goods. There is a further irony. Fraser borrowed Hegel's phrase, the cunning of reason, to describe history outwitting feminism; history, too, has its *mētis*, and the women's cunning may yet be outwitted by it.

The objection from race. hooks's critique, Wynter's account of the overrepresentation of Man, and the comparison with *Set It Off* converge. *Bound*'s Chicago is a sealed white interior, shot in Santa Monica, from which the city's racial geography, mapped by the same Chicago School that theorized its crime, is wholly absent. The film's contraband humanism smuggles goods across the boundaries of gender and sexuality but not across the color line. Its universality is therefore a task rather than a possession, and any theory built upon it must be revised by the films and theories it excludes. Chapter Eight writes that revision into the theory's own terms.

The objection from voyeurism. The worry that the film's sex scenes serve a heterosexual male audience under the cover of "lesbian chic" cannot be dismissed by appeal to intention. Bright's choreography, the refusal of fragmenting cuts, and the ratings board's anxiety over women's sexual competence all count against the charge, and the film's stylized excess (Tilly's voice, the noir décor, the comic extremity of the violence) produces the kind of distance Doane attributed to the masquerade. The film's most effective answer, however, is internal. It builds the voyeur and the fantasist into its plot, as Caesar and Mickey, and defeats both. It cannot defeat the ones in the audience.

The objection from violence. Todd McCarthy objected that love confers on the lovers no privileged state of grace, and Rita Kempley called the film's cruelty gratuitous. Yet the heroines kill one person; the other killings are Caesar's. Violet offers him flight before she fires, and her shots end his assault on Corky. The tradition of tyrannicide supplies the relevant frame. Cicero's *De Officiis* (III.32) held that there can be no fellowship with tyrants and that to kill one is honorable; John of Salisbury's *Policraticus* (1159) held that it is lawful to slay a tyrant; Juan de Mariana's *De rege et regis institutione* (1599) defended the right. Caesar is a tyrant in the strict classical sense, one who rules his household by force for his own advantage. Several reviewers found the violence comically excessive, and the excess functions as distance. The objection is not dissolved but met: the film's violence is not cruelty for its own sake but the ending of a cruelty.

A narrower objection concerns bisexual erasure. Violet's sexual relationships with men, including her secret affair with Shelly, are never named as bisexuality, and Corky's suspicion, which flares when she sees Shelly visiting Violet while Caesar is away, dramatizes a biphobia familiar in lesbian communities. The film partly overcomes the suspicion, since it never requires Violet to account for her past, but it never imagines bisexuality as a position in its own right. The silence is a limit of the film's vocabulary rather than a judgment it renders.

VIII

Chapter Eight

Contraband Humanism

A Theory

The preceding chapters yield a theory that can now be stated in its own terms: a humanism whose goods are real, whose historical distribution was unjust, and which the excluded can therefore possess only as contraband, held together by ligature and acquired through mētis.

8.1 Contraband: Against the Ban

The English *contraband* derives, through Spanish, from the Italian *contrabbando*: *contra*, against, and *bando*, a decree or proclamation of ban. The same *bando* gives *bandito*, one who has been placed under a ban and outlawed: the bandit. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer*, published in 1995, the year before *Bound*, made the ban the original structure of sovereignty. The sovereign includes life in the political order precisely by excluding it, producing the "bare life" of one who may be killed without the killing counting as either homicide or sacrifice. The bandit, the wolf-man of Germanic law, is its figure. Shelly's death, which is neither a legal punishment nor a sacrifice, is bare life under the Family's sovereign ban. The lesbian has existed under a ban in a more literal sense: the Production Code's prohibition, the Padlock Law, the obscenity trial of *The*

Well of Loneliness. Eric Hobsbawm's *Bandits* (1969) described the social bandit, the outlaw whom the poor regard as a champion. Corky partly fits the type, a thief whose crime is against the powerful, and partly exceeds it, because her solidarity is not with a peasantry but with one woman.

A good transmitted by inheritance cannot be legitimately acquired by those barred from inheriting. Pateman and Derrida showed that humanism's goods, contractual freedom and philosophical friendship among them, were transmitted fraternally. The disinherited have three options. They may petition for inclusion, the path of liberal feminism from Wollstonecraft and Mill to the vote and the professions. They may reject the goods as tainted, a path taken by some anti-humanist and separatist positions. Or they may seize them. Contraband humanism names the third option. It holds the goods to be genuinely good (friendship, autonomy, the promise, the dignity of self-fashioning) while denying the legitimacy of their distribution. Stealing does not transform the goods. It relocates them.

8.2 Ligature: The Bond Without Bondage

The Latin *ligatura* derives from *ligare*, to bind, and the verb lies inside the vocabulary of obligation (*obligare*, to bind toward) and, on Lactantius's contested etymology in the *Divine Institutes* (IV.28), of religion itself (*religare*, to bind again). The ligature is therefore not an exotic figure but a buried root of the language of duty and faith. It carries four registers, each of which the film activates.

The first register is typographic. A ligature joins two letters into a single glyph without effacing either: æ, œ, fi. The ampersand itself began as a ligature of the Latin *et*, so that the sign of conjunction is a ligature made visible. Corky *&* Violet.

The second register is surgical. A ligature is the thread that ties off a vessel to stop bleeding. It stanches; it does not conceal. Caesar's laundering hides blood so that circulation may continue. The ligature stops the bleeding so that a life may continue.

The third register is demonological. In early modern Europe, "ligature," in French *nouement d'aiguillette*, the knotting of the codpiece lace, named the spell by which witches were believed to render men impotent. The *Malleus Maleficarum* (1486–87) dwelt on witches' power over male potency, and Jean Bodin's *De la démonomanie des sorciers* (1580) catalogued the knots. Montaigne,

in "De la force de l'imagination" (*Essais* I.21), attributed such impotence to the power of the imagination and recounted curing a friend with a placebo talisman. Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) read the witch-hunt's obsession with women's power over male sexuality as part of a campaign of trials, torture, and executions, conducted by ecclesiastical and secular courts, through which women's bodies were disciplined in the transition to capitalism. The demonological ligature names patriarchy's oldest fear: that a bond among women can suspend the phallic function. Violet's "Everything you couldn't" is the ligature's verdict on Caesar.

The fourth register is ethical, and it is the one this dissertation proposes. An ethical ligature is a bond without bondage: horizontal, binding equals rather than ranking them; revocable, since it could be broken and is not; mutual, since neither party owns the other; epistemic, since it is constituted by acquaintance; and promissory, since it is kept by fidelity rather than enforced by law.

Ligature must be distinguished from fusion. Montaigne's effaced seam, Aristophanes' welded halves, and Bataille's continuity all abolish the two in the one. The ligature preserves the two within the one, as the ampersand preserves both letters of *et*. Lorde asked that difference be treated as a reservoir of creative polarities rather than a threat, and Irigaray's *An Ethics of Sexual Difference* (1984) proposed an ethics of the interval, founded on wonder before an other who is not oneself. The ligature includes the interval within the bond.

Dimension	**Bondage (Caesar's order)**	**Ligature (the women's bond)**
Direction	Vertical: owner and owned, creditor and debtor	Horizontal: equals
Ground	Property, debt, the ban	Acquaintance and promise
Enforcement	Surveillance and violence	Fidelity
Relation to difference	Hierarchy	Polarity without rank
Relation to blood	Laundered and concealed	Stanched
Mode of knowledge	Description: the other as a type	Acquaintance: the other as singular
Typical exit	Death, or flight alone	Departure together

8.3 Mētis: The Mode of the Bound

Chapter Three established the intelligence through which contraband is seized and ligature formed. Its elements can now be gathered. *Mētis* operates in the space of the other, as tactic rather than strategy. It proceeds by adaptation rather than design, re-planning continuously inside a situation it does not control. It works through the hand rather than the eye, and through listening rather than looking. It practices queer use, turning things toward ends for which they were not intended. And, as Detienne and Vernant emphasized, it is an art of binding: its emblems are the net, the noose, and the knot, and its divine craftsman, Hephaestus, binds the adulterous Ares and Aphrodite in an invisible net in the eighth book of the *Odyssey*. *Mētis* has always been an art of ligature. *Bound* redirects that art from trapping to joining. The cunning that once wove nets for enemies weaves, here, a bond between allies.

8.4 The Chiasmus of Knowledge

The film's epistemology can now be stated formally. Caesar possesses an ignorant knowledge. He holds knowledge by description that presents itself as knowledge by acquaintance; he holds a strong theory that absorbs every datum; and he understands knowledge as possession, so that "I know you" means "you are mine." The women possess a learned ignorance. Their acquaintance refuses to harden into description, and they renounce the claim to fix the other within a category. Nicholas of Cusa's *docta ignorantia*, the knowledge of the limits of knowledge before the infinite, is here secularized into an ethics of the other. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) supplies the corresponding terms. Totality is the attempt to comprehend the other within the same; infinity is the other's overflowing of every idea I can form of her. Caesar's knowledge is totality. The women's is infinity.

The chiasmus is exact. Caesar claims to know and does not. The women decline to claim such knowledge and in fact possess it: they predict, adapt, and trust correctly. Across the film, the curve of Caesar's actual knowledge descends as his claims grow louder, and the curve of the women's knowledge ascends as their claims grow quieter. The curves cross at the moment of the heist, and the film's final words, examined in the Coda, are spoken from the far side of the crossing.

8.5 Twelve Theses on Contraband Humanism

I. Every humanism has a mode of transmission. The canonical humanism of the West was transmitted patrilineally and fraternally, as an inheritance among brothers, and its goods could be possessed only by those positioned to inherit. The disinherited can acquire them only by expropriation. *Bound* is the narrative form of that expropriation.

II. The general equivalent is one. Money, father, phallus, monarch, and logos occupy homologous positions. To steal the money from the figure in whom all five converge is to steal them all; the heist is not a metaphor for liberation but its structural equivalent.

III. Laundering is the paradigmatic operation of patriarchal capital: the conversion of blood into abstraction. Critique begins by making the laundering visible, and *Bound* begins its plot there.

IV. Ignorance is both a power and a vulnerability. The sovereign's ignorance of what exceeds his categories is the precondition of his rule and the instrument of his ruin. Derealization, the lesbian's historical burden, can be converted into stealth.

V. *Mētis* is the intelligence of the bound. It operates in the space of the other, by adaptation rather than design, through the hand rather than the eye, by listening rather than looking, and it binds.

VI. The ligature is a bond without bondage: horizontal, revocable, mutual, constituted by acquaintance, and kept by promise. It differs from bondage not in its strength but in its direction, and from fusion in that it preserves the two within the one.

VII. Noir is the genre of the prisoner's dilemma resolved by defection. *Bound* resolves it by cooperation, not by abolishing distrust but by transforming it, through erotic knowledge, into an acquaintance that no interrogation can break.

VIII. Violence appears where power fails. The sovereign's violence measures his loss of power; the ligature's single act of violence ends a domination and founds none.

IX. The goods of humanism are real; their historical distribution was criminal. Contraband humanism retains the goods (friendship, autonomy, the promise, the dignity of self-fashioning) while refusing the legitimacy of their distribution.

X. Contraband humanism is compromised by its means and honest about its compromise. Stolen goods remain goods, and the master's money funds the exit from the master's house, not its dismantling. Its horizon is fugitive, not revolutionary.

XI. Contraband humanism is bounded. Its first instance smuggles goods across the borders of gender and sexuality but not across the color line. Its universality is a task rather than a possession, to be completed by those its first instance left behind.

XII. The philosophers have only interpreted the human in various ways; the point is to steal it, and then, as the debt the theft itself incurs, to give it away.

The twelfth thesis turns the eleventh of Marx's *Theses on Feuerbach* against the fraternal horizon within which Marx wrote it. Its second clause names the theory's utopian remainder. Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) described the threefold obligation to give, to receive, and to reciprocate, and the Maori *hau*, the spirit of the gift that seeks to return to its source or to travel onward. Stolen humanism carries such a *hau*. *Bound* shows the theft but not the gift; it ends with two women, a truck, and a fortune, and leaves the obligation to circulate what they have taken unperformed. Corky's own name for the crime that sent her to prison, "redistribution of wealth," names the demand the film leaves standing. That obligation is Ernst Bloch's not-yet, the horizon on which Muñoz located queerness. The film does not reach it. It points toward it.



Coda

"Me Neither"

The film ends with a question about difference that neither lover can answer, and their shared failure to answer it is the film's last and most exact philosophical act.

Mickey has promised Violet that he will find Caesar, and has asked her to stay with him. She has told him she needs a clean break. She leaves with Corky, hand in hand, and as they go the last words of the film are exchanged:

Corky
You know what the difference is between you and me, Violet?

Violet
No.

Corky
Me neither.

Tom Jones begins to sing, and they drive away.

The exchange inverts the epistemology of the entire genre. Noir depends on difference, above all on the difference between the femme fatale and the sap, between the one who knows and the one who is played. Every noir conspiracy ends by revealing such a difference, by disclosing who was using whom. *Bound*'s final scene poses the very question that should produce the

revelation and answers it with a shared unknowing. There is no difference to reveal because there was no betrayal. The line also answers an earlier claim: Violet had told Corky that they were more alike than Corky cared to admit, and the last exchange concedes the point without reducing either woman to the other. The question that, in Cain and Wilder, precedes the gunshot here precedes a departure.

The line bears several readings, and each confirms an argument of this dissertation. Irigaray made sexual difference the philosophical question of our age; the lovers' unknowing is the scene in which a relation proceeds without being organized by it. Yet the film does not thereby erase difference. Butch and femme, laborer and kept woman, thief and companion of the launderer remain distinct to the end. What dissolves is not difference but hierarchy, which is why Lorde's account of difference as a reservoir of creative polarities describes the scene better than any theory of sameness. Derrida's *différance* names a difference that cannot be presented because it precedes and conditions every identity, and the lovers cannot name their difference for the same reason: it is not a property either of them holds but the condition of the relation between them. Class difference, which the film encoded in kinds of crime, is carried away in a single vehicle. The moral difference noir requires, between the user and the used, is abolished by being declined.

The epistemological reading is decisive. Caesar died claiming to know the difference between himself and Violet, the difference between owner and owned. The women live by declining to know theirs. The chiasmus of ignorant knowledge and learned ignorance completes itself in two words. Jackie Stacey titled her essay on women's looks at women "Desperately Seeking Difference"; here the seeking ends not in finding but in a shared not-finding. This is not the collapse of desire into identification that de Lauretis feared, because the scene is a scene of desire: two lovers, their hands joined, leaving together.

The fusion models of friendship and love describe the moment almost, but not quite. Montaigne's souls efface the seam that joined them; Aristophanes' lovers ask to be welded into one; Bataille's lovers taste, for an instant, the continuity of which their discontinuous existence deprives them. In each, the two become one. In *Bound*, the two remain two and are joined. The grammar of the exchange already says so. Violet answers with a negation; Corky answers her negation with another, and the word that joins them, *neither*,

binds two refusals into a single agreement. Two negatives, ligatured, make the film's one affirmation.

And so the film ends where contraband humanism begins: with the human smuggled out of the house that claimed to own it. The song on the soundtrack, a heterosexual crooner's chivalric anthem, has been stolen too, and repurposed, like the money, for those it was never meant to serve. Two people who do not know the difference between them drive away with a fortune that was never theirs and a future that is. They have taken what humanism withheld. What they owe for it, the film leaves, as it should, to the road ahead.

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Keywords

Bound (*1996*) / *Lana Wachowski* / *Lilly Wachowski* / *neo-noir* / *film noir* / *femme fatale* / *lesbian representation* / *butch-femme* / *contraband humanism* / *ligature* / mētis / *general equivalent* / *traffic in women* / *sexual contract* / *homosocial desire* / *epistemology of the closet* / *apparitional lesbian* / *straight mind* / *masquerade* / *female masculinity* / acousmêtre / *anti-ocularcentrism* / *prisoner's dilemma* / *erotic epistemology* / *promise* / *power and violence* / *philosophical friendship* / *voluntary servitude* / *recognition* / *lordship and bondage* / *commodity fetishism* / *money laundering* / *debt and cruelty* / *tactics* / *queer use* / Nachträglichkeit / *reparative reading* / *trans hermeneutics* / *queer futurity* / *New Queer Cinema* / *Bona Dea* / *tyrannicide* / *feminist film theory* / *humanism* / *posthumanism*